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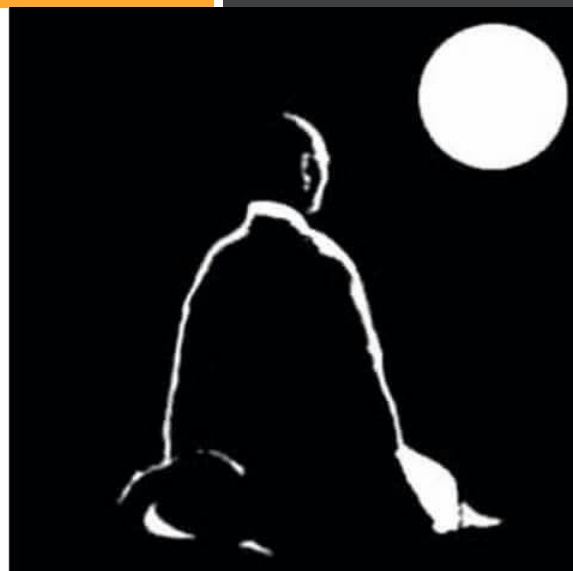
From the Editor in Chief's desk:
By Swami Paranand Tirth

EDITOR IN CHIEF: SWAMI PARANAND TIRTH



On being what you essentially are Swaroop Labh.

There is a popular-argument put forward by the votaries of monism to refute dualists who



<https://www.pinterest.com/dhitasuth/zen-japanese-chinese-painting/>

propound that the ultimate purport of the revelations is duality and plurality . The argument suggests that the sense of duality is innate and spontaneous in all sentient beings so why should the revelations infuse a notion that is already there .

अज्ञातज्ञापकत्वात् शास्त्राणाम्

Revelations and revelationability is consistent only in as much as it pertains to some experience that cannot be had otherwise I.e. through conventional means of knowledge.

Patanjali's school of yoga says to be established in your essential nature you must completely restrain all fluctuations of the mind matter otherwise you are merely riding the tide of your own mind -wavering .If you are not being your Self you are in unison with unregulated produces of your own reciprocating thought constructs . Tantras aim at simplifying otherwise complicated and arduous yogic means by following certain knacks or upayas or by communion with the source of spiritual energy which leads to shaktipat or induction of the energy .

This experience of an aspirant's essential nature conflicts the experience accumulated in the psyche by a perpetuated trail of aberrant divergence of awareness . Merely a scholastic disillusionment about one's essential nature can't generate the genuine experience . Besides dialectic conclusions this also requires the specially generated stream line of consciousness that we have discussed in the preceding editorial 'Mahasahas Vritti'. This dawns by the munificence of the guru and generates an experience that annuls the divergence and drift caused by the absence of unison with one's essential nature .

There is a subtle difference between Swaroope Avastha Nam. स्वरूपे अवस्थानाम् and Swaroop Labha स्वरूपलाभः . In the former state your seat in your essential nature lasts only till your awareness gets divergent and is in unison with thought constructs or vrittis. Attainment of the essential nature on the other hand is once and for ever. The moment is expressed by Vatul Nath in this aphorism:

महासाहसवृत्तांत स्वरूपलाभः।

The upanisads also propounds this instant of epiphany. Kenopanisad describes this phenomena with its aesthetic mystique

इत्यनीनिमिषत्आ३।

All this happened in a flash .

The instant of epiphany is a time transcendental phenomena.and instant of transition between the time conditioned and time transcendent cannot be an oft repeated process.

Swami Paranand Tirth
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Editorial



With the emergence of Modernism in West the reasoning faculty was developed manifold. This rational era taught that one needs empirical proof to understand and believe any phenomenon. If something did not look or sound logical one could easily relegate it to the realm of blind belief and superstition. The products of this system did not value intuition much and hence no importance was given to this form of knowledge. In the field of art such cold cut logic was questioned by movements like Symbolism and Surrealism to some extent but its impact on human psyche and human thinking process continues in contemporary times too.

There are constant studies on Ancient wisdom and the secrets of universe, which keep proposing one or the other theory basing them on some scientific, historic or literal proof. So much so that many traditional scholars have started using similar methodologies to explain their stand point and hence joined the band wagon e.g. to explain classical calm and subtle grace in Gupta sculptures it is often compared to Classical Greek art. The psychological need for approval from West while on one hand points at 'Colonial Hangover' on the other it creates an atmosphere for considering all traditional forms of knowledge as backward and 'illogical'.

The point is brought forth by Swami Paranand Tirth ji in his insightful editorial where he stresses on the fact that revealed knowledge does not fall in the purview of duality and hence merely a scholastic disillusionment about one's essential nature can't generate the genuine experience. Besides dialectic conclusions this also requires the specially generated stream line of consciousness that Swamiji has discussed in the preceding editorial 'Mahasahas Vritti'.

Next we have Swamiji's conversations with Dr. Sisir Roy on the nature of vibration and quantum vacuum, a notion that has been engaging and intriguing modern day scientists. The questions raised by the latter have been succinctly answered by Swamiji citing relevant examples wherever necessary. The concepts that quantum physics is dealing with have been contemplated upon by hoary seers and given due importance in their writings. Some of these notions like Spanda, Maatrisva and Chidakasha have been discussed in these extremely perceptive and discerning correspondences.

Following this we have Dr. Shashishekhar Toshkhani's thought provoking write-up on Lalleshwari, a female mystic seer of Kashmir whose cryptic verses are full of spiritual teachings which were revealed to her first hand during various meditative processes she went through. As the author writes "The purpose of this paper is to examine some of the image constructs of the saint-poetess which are patently false, and have no basis in facts, but are passed on as products of genuine scholarship. These images and fabrications are being circulated persistently with surprising frequency not out of any desire to present the truth, but to suppress it"

Next we have Neeraj Santoshi Khar's tribute to Prof. Subhash Kak, giving a glimpse into

latter's scholarship. Apart from Kak's scholarship he also talks in detail about his passion for Kashmir and ancient wisdom.

This is followed by an enlightening article by Prof Subhash Kak on 'Art and Cosmology in India'. According to him the best way to understand India is through its art and the cosmology. He stresses that textbook narratives often overlook the synthesizing principles that represent the

grammar of Indian culture, and they are much like the accounts of the six blind people who encountering an elephant describe it as wall, spear, snake, tree, rope, and fan, respectively.

In the end we have a photo feature on the recent Kailash Mansarovar Yatra via Simikot, Hilsa and Taklakot undertaken by Swamiji in May 2016. The scenic photographs give a blissful glimpse of this holy pilgrimage.

(Dr. Geetika Kaw Kher is Asst. Professor at Amity School of Fine Arts (ASFA) and teaches History of Art, Aesthetics and Art Criticism)

Physics versus metaphysics

(Correspondence between Dr.Sisir Roy and
Paranand Swami)

Respected Swamiji,

Niraj Kumar told me about you and your writings in the Newsletters.I am delighted to read some of your articles on Rhythm, cosmic Dance etc".

I tried to communicate to you through gmail but it bounced. I requested Niraj to talk to you about some matter related to 'vibration" or "spanda" from scientific point of view which I have already written in my last mail..

Since vibration can not be thought of as a-temporal or a-spatial and without the existence of the medium, we scientists face the problem of understanding.I will be delighted if you enlighten me in this regard.

Warm regards,
Sisir roy

Swamiji:

Blessed self,

The problem of understanding lies with the view point . The scientific process is purely objective and quantitative it can hardly explain any mystic, supernatural or extra spatial phenomena. A metaphysical perspective is deficit in quantitative inference and can be of a very little or no scientific authenticity . If a quantum physicist were also to be a gentleman of some mystic bent and vice versa both would also like to go subjectively and qualitatively about this phenomenon . Let me give you a tantrik semiotic semblance of the quantum vacuum and an iota of electric charge that scientists discovered on it . In an absolute void , atemporal as you call it there is a very minute charge that accrues from the mystic process of shiva getting condensed as Shakti the primeval

energy that denoted dynamism within the shell of perfect vacuum or shiva

There union is signified by the fourth vowel which is realised as the eternal word by yogins of great spiritual accomplishment .

वियदीकारसंयुक्तं वीतिहोत्र समन्वितं अर्धदुलसितं
देव्याः बीजं

सर्वार्थसाधकं

The void I.e. ह is comparable to quantum vacuum

र the fire or energy when unites with it I.e.

after.a fraction of the chidakash or the conscious space been condensed is into the form of energy . With nada which is a latent form of vibration this great tantrik encryption has all the mystery of the power and process of the universal phenomena embedded in it .

Instead of an insentient vacuum our ancient seers conceptualized or realised the existence of a conscious ether चिदंबरम who is capable of contracting himself in the form of energy or Shakti and who further accounts for the process of spanda or creative divergence .

Respected Swamiji,

I am delighted to get your response. However, the issue is precisely the following :

(1) The concept "spanda" seems to be a kind of "vibration " of "kincit chalan" a throbbing. This creates the phenomenal world. This has a striking similarity with the concept of fluctuation of quantum vacuum.

Swamiji'reply

There is an interesting resemblance between ancient orthodox energy definition of Spanda and your specification . We consider spanda as a sentient vibrant entity which pervades the or rather embraces the entire universal phenomena and at the same time transcends it . This is similar to the mind charge that quantum physicists recently observed whin quantum vacuum.

हंतानंतस्फुरत्ता जयंति जगति सा शांकरी
स्पंदशक्तिः

The author of spanada Karika defines spanda while felicitating it ,as shiva power of oscillation . Now given that shiva is comparable to quantum vacuum I.e the zone of zero objectivity Shakti or to more precise spanda Shakti of shiva is the primordial divergent creative impulse that manifests in the form of three conditionings viz Time ,space and substance continuum . I have added substance or वस्तु to this continuum because in our ancient canons the infinite as subjective consciousness has three fold conditioning or अनंत as conditioned in time is called eternity or absolute time . Ananta can also be defined as subjectively conscious quantum vacuum with zero objectivity this on being conditioned in space is defined as अखण्ड or the spatial substratum . The absolute universal principle as per the Upanishadic power and process of universal manifestation generates grosser material manifestation of ether ,air ,fire water and earth and then pervades these in such a manner that he interlaces these without any actual modification . Then there is the process of divergence according the attributes of these five basic constituents of the universal phenomena namely sound as that of the ether sound and touch as the attributes of air ,sound ,touch and sight of fire and sound ,touch ,sight ,and taste as the four attributes of water .

Your hunch or let's call it intuitive insight just falls in with such notions in our ancient revelations regarding spacetime continuum. besides these two the third "Substance- conditioning " of the absolute principle is also considered in our ancient texts . Space or Akash in its subtle most form is not just a medium which might as well be absent in the parlance of quantum vacuum but the space transcendent subjectively conscious substratum . Shiva as the guru or supreme preceptor has been felicitated as व्योमवत् व्याप्त देह I.e. Manifesting as the omnipresent ether or

चिदाकाश . As per the notion of chidakash it must pervade even quantum dot or quantum vacuum which as I figure out is the line of demarcation between actual and intellectual notion . Substance is added as the third condition since the original subtle notion of ether is akin to what quantum science understands as quantum vacuum . We have a description of five gradations of subtlety in the tantric canons .being the subtlest and most pervasive ether is contained in solid ,fluid,energy ,and dynamic manifestation of nature the fifth form of Akash is called (चिदाकाश) or conscious ether .this is the twilight zone of mind matter juncture . The gross ether as a part of the gross penta-dimensional phenomena ,the subtler ether as subtler ether that pervades the rest of the four elements ,chittakash or the ether that pervades individual intelligence comprising cognitive,volition,imaginative and self determining faculties . The subtle most or chidakash or conscious ether exhibits similar characteristics of QV . If this चिदाकाश by any stroke of chance turns out be also pervading quantum vacuum owing to space transcendent nature of the both . Mind and energy as the primordial building brick of the universal phenomena can be consistent from either perspective I.e physical as well spiritual .

Dr.Roy

Why this fluctuation in vacuum ? We assume that Quantum Principle is valid everywhere - not only in phenomenal world. So according to Heisenberg Uncertainty principle, there will be enormous fluctuation of energy during a very short period of time.

Swami Ji's reply

Heisenberg is right in his own place but is this just an arbitrary behaviour of insentient matter or the design of highly ingenious nature of the supreme being ?

The agency that accounts for this fluctuation or let's say spanda in the eternal still quietude of

the sentient ether or cidakash is in fact the process of Shiva manifesting as Shakti. This divergent outflux or spandanam is the second succession of modification, the first being the atman creating ether the second step is air or rit springing forth from the primordial ether.

The nearest parallel of "quantum " in the parlance of consciousness specially when it comes to subjective consciousness has been called sphota स्फोट in our metaphysics .Like energy, consciousness also propagates in the form of small units or packages termed as Quantas and sphota respectively .Ancient seers conceptualised this process as pertaining to expressible word I.e either a syllable or word or sentence .

Energy शक्ति in this context is defined as the power of consciousness that accounts for the relation of word with its meaning . This semblance leads us to the consistency of quantum physics principles in the realm of consciousness .

Awareness as such manifests in the form of word and meaning which are known as nad नाद and बिंदु (nada being the point of absolute convergence of collective word and Bindu the point of absolute convergence of collective meaning) .**Eastern metaphysics emphasises on the Nada aspect whereas modern science focuses on the notion of Bindu, objectively though .**

Sisir Roy:

(2) Concept of Quantum Vacuum : Various type of fields are there and hence concept of space time is there.

(3) My hunch is that space time itself is generated by this fluctuation.

But we do not really understand this process?

Swamiji's reply

As I have said above your hunch just falls in with the Upanishadic dictum regarding the power and process of the creation or let us say the manifestation of the universal phenomena .

...from this self I.e. Pure subjective consciousness ether springs forth from the ether air and from ether air(tattiriya upanisad)

If the ether were to be compared to quantum vacuum then the secondary manifestations air or dynamism and energy follow . The " will to create " interlaces all the following varieties of grosser manifestation . As another Upanishad Antaryami Brahman goes ... **“one who interlaces ether knows ether but whose ether doesn't know ,one who indwells air who knows air but whom air knows not”**

These are the ultimate postulations by our hoary seers in a parlance of mind matter relationship . We must conceptualise matter as insentient and the underlying streamline of consciousness as pervading various gradations of subtlety and grossness of matter and accounting for their respective characteristics . These are based on intuitive insight and not on scientific observation therefore these are assimilated better through faith and devotion .

Shri Aurobindo writes in his synthesis of yoga – “energy in the power and process of creation is matter and spirit in the power and process of creation is mind” . Off late there has been a sort of innovation in the post shankarite monism to ignore all other schools of thought as meant for less competent and extrovert aspirants . So all talks of insentient matter converting into living protoplasm stand refuted. The conscious substratum must be preconceived which before converting into dynamic perpetuation or spanda out of still a temporal void or vacuum exerts his own free will .

स्वस्मिन् स्वात्म स्वभित्तौ कलयति
धरणीमाशिवांतं जगद्या

हंतानंतस्फुरत्ता जयतिजगति सा
शांकरीस्पंदशक्तिः

(propitiatory verse of spand karika)

Within the canvas of her own conscious substratum she creates this universe consisting of thirty six elements from earth to shiva .

From the stand point of quantum physics it IS may be too early to conclude anything but from an eastern metaphysical perspective the divine will of the universal being accounts for this mystic phenomena of spanda .

This is the very nature of the lord but how can a complete and content being have any wish to manifest or procreate?

देवस्यैषस्वभावोयं आप्तकामकामस्य का स्पृहा
(Gaud padacharya)

Sisir Roy:

(4) May be here lies the mystery of "spanda".

(5) Concept of ānda" or ěgg" principle is considered in Indian Philosophy.

I think it is a metaphor - like Hiranyagarbha or "tathagatagarbha" in Lankavatar sutra.

Sometimes I wonder why this metaphor of "garbha" or "womb" was introduced.

Can you enlighten me in these issues ?

Swamiji's reply

As per the Indian law of causation the effect cannot supersede the cause so even with all its reciprocations the objective phenomena cannot transcend the substratum which is the pure subjective consciousness Which as you define is a temporal and time transcendent entity .

The expanse of the lords vision is same whether the universal phenomena is completely extant or it is when it is dormant in a seed form ,one canon on tantric metaphysics says .Hence the analogy of the yolk of an egg or a womb . The Veda propound an intermediate stage that predates actual creation as hiranyagarbha or the golden womb .

Hiranyagarbha manifested in the beginning The creator of all beings and their lord . He sustained the earth and the heavens ,to him do we offer oblations (rikveda)

When the a priori of creation is an existent entity we call it the golden womb or hiranyagarbha . When the ultimate is required to be pronounced as essencelessness or nisvabhavata then we call it tathagata garbha . But the basic idea is the same .

The maxim of the yolk of a peahen egg is popular among the Shaivites of Kashmir
मयूरांडरसन्यायः न्यायः . All colourful beauty of the plumage tuft and feathers of a peacock are dormant in the yolk of its egg . Apparently it looks only a white colour less jelly with a lump of yellow mass . **Like wise within the quantum vacuum or perhaps the concept of QCD the chromodynamic blue print of creation may be encrypted in a dormant seed form .** The quantum chromodynamics phenomena may be a projection of some more discreet design of future manifestation embedded in the sub nuclear realms . The semiotics of a peahen egg just befits the context .

It would be a great break through if the string theory of electronic physics could be related to the ancient concept of सूत्रात्मा -a fine filament

of living energy or प्राण which pervades the individual subtle body and the cosmic subtle body or hiranyagarbha .

I hope this philosophising is of some use to you

Yours in the lord .

Swami paranand tirth .

Sisir Roy:

Swamiji could you please throw some light on the 4th mantra of Isavasyasyopanisad and concept of 'Maatrisva'.

Swamiji's explanation:

In this particular mantra of Isavasyasyopanisad, Tamsin -within him , refers to the conscious and subjective space or chidakash. This concept falls in with the notion of quantum vacuum except that there is no scientific proof of its being a subjectively sentient entity as of now . There are two entities mentioned in this mantra आप and मातरिश्व instead of using the dictionary, meaning "water" I chose to define it as "fluidity "dynamic flow which is similar to अप and मातरिश्वा .we have two other Vedic mantras which rule out these two as insentient material entities . One is from Brihadaranyaka it says ता आप ऐक्षत the waters cogitated and another mantra from rikveda containing the term matarishwa which sayanacharya interprets as मातरि आकाशे श्वयति श्वसिति इति

मातरिश्वा (an entity which respire in the conscious ether)

The crux is that both fluidity or aap and dynamism or matarishwa are sentient

modifications of a sentient ether or chidakash . No fluctuation or movement can ever exceed the domain of their substratum hence these are contained within it . This is where scientific advancement and mystic insights meet.

My wavelength is more in tune with Upanishadic and tantrik thought therefore I defined aap as fluidity and matarishwa as dynamism.the primordial divergent flutter or spanda may be reflected in the phenomena that accounts for the manifestation of electrical charge (aap and matarishwa) in quantum vacuum.

The other day I was watching a video of group discussion ,One eminent scientist called all this "spooof- physics " being construed to vindicate hackneyed metaphysics,This doesn't have to be so with ingenious scientists like you who also have a bent for our metaphysical heritage . And therefore also trying to tie up the loose ends accordingly .

Yours in the lord

Swami paranand tirth .

Sisir Roy:

Respected Swamiji,

I am delighted to get your response regarding the meaning of the word

"maatarisva" in Mantra 4 of Isopanisad.

You say :vacuum is fluid dynamic.

This is very interesting from the point of view of modern physics.

In modern cosmology we say that the universe is originated from the fluctuation of Quantum vacuum.

Now when you say fluid dynamic : why you say fluid instead of saying simply space;

If we decompose this word into two parts :
maatri and svas ;

maatri is related to mother means measure. So we can say space is the substratum of measure or distance because unless there is measure or simply distance. you can not create any form.

One can think of the principle of Maya at the very beginning also. Again the word maya is related to ma or to measure. Whenever you say measure, it means limitation and hence illusion created about the ultimate reality. I read somewhere that "maatarisva" means space which breathes i.e. in our terminology we say fluctuation of space.

Why this fluctuation - because of the existence of Heisenberg uncertainty principle in quantum theory.

According to this principle, during very short duration of time, there will be huge fluctuation of energy which gives rise to the universe.

Now very interesting question comes :

Whether space itself fluctuates or the existence of certain kind of fluctuation of fluid, makes the space fluctuation occur.

I will be delighted if you explain me why you choose fluid.

Warm regards,

sisir roy

Swamiji:

Blessed self

I have also included the word अपः that precedes matarishwa . Both have

A special type of dynamism is common I.e. A temporal displacement .

Fluid, as one of my dictionaries defines it is a substance subject to continuous deformation under some pressure or force . Vayu or spirit has no form and flows continuously motivated by the power of will or action or knowledge . ज्ञान इच्छा and क्रिया , so I thought fluid and fluidity was more conveying . If one reflected on the first half of the mantra

तद्वावतो अन्यान्यत्येति तिष्ठन् it tells us about the fluctuation within the substratum of a static vacuum . An extra temporal displacement !

I deliberately chose the term fluid or Fluidity because it denotes primordial movement in the still and stagnant ether or to be more precise the conscious ether .In the arcane tantrik ontology this is defined as Shakti tatvan.

The. Just movement cannot explain any supra temporal displacement .

This is more efficaciously explained in Pratyabhijna Hridayam as the

Unfolding of universal phenomena within her(while referring to chiti or chitshakti) own domain which predates the manifestation of time ,space and substance .

The divine mother whom we adore as the power of consciousness spoke through the daughter of a Vedic seer in first person ..I flow like wind and generate the entire universe .अहमेववात इव प्रवाम्यारभमाणा भुवनानि विश्वा etc this a very inspiring suktam of rikveda called Devi suktam or at a suktam .

Some votaries of monism refer to this Shakti as maya or the innate beginningless delusive power of the lord and also attribute the process. Of creation to her .this concept is presumably for the less gifted ones . Real vedantist do not reject the universal as virtual or ephemeral but "maintain that it is real till it appears so .

What I mean by "fluid or fluidity is the first dynamic to modification within चिदाकाश .

There is a reasoning of the order of subtlety and pervasiveness so space as such pervades all grosser manifestations too . So instead of space or Akash I enunciated fluidity as air or energy or spirit .The nearest parallel of quantum vacuum is eastern metaphysics .

Movement according to QD is a tiny iota of energy which one scientist friend told me was discovered within the quantum vacuum . The entire power and process of creation from the absolute principle getting conditioned in the form of ether ,dynamic air or spirit, energy,plasma and finally the solid seems to be latently encrypted in the realm of sub nucleonic minuteness. In our previous communication we discussed the analogy and semblance of quantum chromodynamics and मयूरांडरसन्ध्यायः I.e. Maxim of a peahens egg.

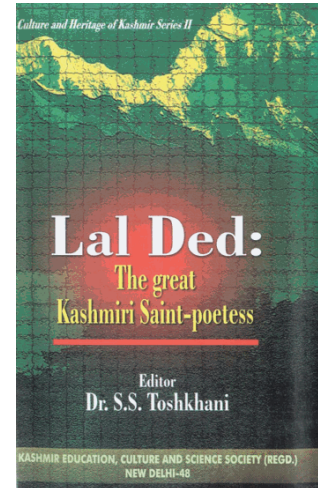
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Prana or energy i.e. The first manifestation of dynamism within a static shell as the mantra we are discussing signifies the first portion of the word सत्यम् or truth I.e. सत् which is ether and air or the invisible portion of the phenomena . The other half त्यत् signifies the perceivable phenomena

Or fire ,water and earth. The unison of these two I.e. Subjective and objective portions of the universe ,according to our Upanishadic seers is the spiritual truth . Quantum physics as it were seems to be striving for this truth, in its own way though .

Yours in the lord

Swami Paranand tirth



Reconstructing and Reinterpreting Lal Ded

Dr. S.S. Toshkhani

Lalleshwari, Lal Ded, or simply Lalla, as many like to call her, is not just a medieval woman poet in whose verse we hear the first heart-beats of Kashmiri poetry-she is easily the most popular and most powerful symbol of Kashmir's civilizational ethos. While her 'vaaks' or verse-sayings continue to dazzle us with their high wattage incandescence, her role as a spiritual leader who resolved the crisis of her times caused by a clash of two belief and value systems-one indigenous and the other alien cannot but be regarded as momentous, whether or not history recognizes its true significance. In both these capacities it was her intervention that ensured continuity and saved indigenous cultural structures from a total collapse at a time when the advent of Islam in Kashmir was accompanied by an unprecedented political and social upheaval.

If Lal Ded's immense impact on the Kashmiri mind has practically remained undiminished despite the passage of almost seven centuries, it is essentially because of the fusion of the poet and the saint in her, or, to use the words of Dileep Chitre (which he has used for another great Bhakti poet, Tukaram), because of "a poet's vision of spirituality and a saint's vision of poetry" that she presents in her verses. We

are amazed at her deep sense of compassion, her mystical insights and spiritual vision, her profound awareness of the human condition and her Shaiva-world view which makes her look at existence as manifestation of one, indivisible, consciousness. More than anything else, we are indebted to her for shaping the Kashmiri language in a way that it formed the basis for the Kashmiris to forge their indigenous cultural identity.

Ironically, this very image of Lal Ded as a spiritual giant and poetic genius fused into one-reinforced by the many hagiographical accounts, myths and legends surrounding her-has led to attempts at appropriating her for ideologies and causes totally alien to her thinking and temperament. We thus come across not one but several image constructs of the saint-poetess, some of them mutually irreconcilable, linked inextricably with predilections, perceptions and motives of those who have created them. And these tend to blur and distort facts about her life, making it extremely difficult for us to arrive at what we can call an authentic Lal Ded-a flesh and blood Lal Ded occupying a specific space and time in history, or at least a poetic version of what Lal Ded was or must actually have been like. With whims, fancies and notions being the basis of these various constructs, we are left with the problems of exploring the true dimensions of her creativity and of locating the real founts of her inspiration. And this cannot be settled by

mere interpretations of scholarly differences or semantic hair-splitting. The task has been made immensely complicated by the intervention of nearly seven hundred years of history about which people are still hesitant to talk freely and openly.

The purpose of this paper is to examine some of the image constructs of the saint-poetess which are patently false, and have no basis in facts, but are passed on as products of genuine scholarship. These images and fabrications are being circulated persistently with surprising frequency not out of any desire to present the truth, but to suppress it. The most formidable attempt to appropriate Lal Ded in this manner comes from those who want to snatch her for Islam. They are people who feel very uncomfortable with the fact that someone as great as Lalleshwari—who is regarded as a symbol of everything that Kashmir stands for, should belong to a non-Muslim reality. Masquerading as scholars but motivated and conditioned by their religious reflexes, they try to subvert this fact by floating imaginary anecdotes about her conversion to Islam. One such anecdote that continues to be repeated with total disregard to historical plausibility is that she met Sayyid Mir Ali Hamadani, the Islamic missionary most revered by Kashmiri Muslims, and received "spiritual enlightenment" from him. Sayyid Hamadani had come to Kashmir with a large entourage of fellow Sayyids to escape the wrath of Timur and there he engaged in proselytizing activities on a massive scale. Prof. Jaya Lal Kaul has in his brilliantly researched book "Lal Ded" very convincingly proved the utter impossibility of such a meeting having ever taken place. Referring to Persian sources, he has quoted Mohammad Azam Dedamari's explicit statement that the story of her being present before the Sayyid "has not been held as proved by scholars". Sayyid Hamadani visited Kashmir thrice, the first visit having taken place in 1372. And if Lal Ded died in the reign of Shihab-ud-din, as Persian chronicles point out, he could in no way have influenced her. Persian chronicler Peer Ghulam Hassan, too makes no mention of a meeting

between Lal Ded and Sayyid Mir Ali Hamadani, but states that she did indeed meet Jalal-ud-din Bukhari and Sayyid Hussain Samanani and it was at his hands that she was "converted" to Islam. 'Bibi Lalla Arifa', a pamphlet published from Lahore, to which Prof. Jayalal Kaul has referred, is more categorical, saying that she accepted Islam at the hands of Sayyid Hussain Samanani. "This should be obvious to all", the pamphlet adds, emphasizing the claim and giving a fanciful account of the supposed meeting. According to the pamphlet, Lal Ded ran for miles together to receive Sayyid Samanani at Shopian and "being elated to receive the secret doctrine, became his chief disciple". Repudiating this claim which Sufi, the author of "Kashir", a history of Kashmir published from Pakistan, says is based on "Lalla Arifa's own later day vaaks," Prof. Kaul writes: "Not a single verse-saying of hers has been discovered up to date even among the doubtful and spurious verse-sayings ascribed to her which would bear out either this anecdote or similar other anecdotes concerning her".

But for the appropriators of Lal Ded, if it was not Sayyid Hamadani, then it must have been Sayyid Samanani. Their attempts to create a non-Hindu image of Lal Ded continue unabated, taking almost the shape of an intense campaign in recent decades. A special Lal Ded Number (1979) of Sheeraza, a journal published by the Jammu and Kashmir State Art Culture and Languages, for instance, is illustrative of this obsession which shows itself in article after article obviously with the editor's tacit agreement. One such article "Lal Ded Shah Hamadan ke Huzoor Mein" (Lal Ded in the Presence of Shah Hamadan), written by Mufti Jalal-ud-din, says, "It does not matter whether these anecdotes are corroborated by history or not. It is eventually popular belief that settles the issue". Jalal-ud-din's is not just an individual opinion—it represents a whole mindset that shows no signs of changing even today. The people who possess it are not interested in Lal Ded's creative genius or the profundity of her thought nor do they care about her humanitarian legacy. They are driven by the sole objective of

grabbing what can be called "Hindu intellectual property". That is why they show Lal Ded running towards a baker's oven desperate to cover her nudity as she had seen a "man" when she supposedly encountered Sayyid Hamadani. The miracle of the oven is surely prompted by a hegemonistic design to establish the superiority of Islam over the creed of the "infidels". Sayyid Hamadani was on a proselytizing mission and what bigger fish could there have been for him to cast his net ?

The Sufi image that some have tried to foist on Lal Ded is also a mischievous and motivated construct as it is virtually an attempt to de-Hinduise her and to create confusion about her faith. The man who began it all, though not exactly with that intention, Sir Richard Temple, appears indeed to have been a confused person, saying different things at different places. At one place he says that Lalla was a Shaivite Hindu and at another place he discovers that "she deeply and quickly absorbed the Sufi line of thought after her contact with her contemporary and friend" Sayyid Ali Hamadani. Soon afterwards he counts similarities in "the doctrine and practice of Naqshbandis and the Yogic exercises of the Hindu Shaivas". Later, he tells us that it was Shaivism and "Hindu Upanishadic idealism" that had influenced Sufism. If that be the truth then how is it that she is influenced by Sufism as preached by Sayyid Ali Hamadani? Why not directly by Hindu Upanishadic thought? If Sayyid Hamadi was at all a Sufi, he was not of the type who would believe in the doctrine of Wahadat-ul-Wujud or oneness of existence and certainly not in universal brotherhood and love. The humiliating and degrading conditions he laid down in his book "Zakhirat-ul-Muluk" to guide a Sultan in treating his non-Muslim subjects are enough to prove this. The various Sufi orders said to have been introduced during that time in Kashmir were all orthodox in nature, preaching strict adherence to Shariah and not liberal humanism as is made out to be. They remained confined to the correct practice of the Quranic beliefs and "hardly came out of zuhd, ibadat, taqwa and riyadat, the limits set by their

founders", having nothing to do with the type of Sufism based on the doctrine of Mohi-ud-din ibn Arabi. Their emphasis was on proselytization and not on the belief in unity of being and universal love.

Writers like P.N.K. Bamzai and Dr. R.K. Parmu, who followed Richard Temple in his queer conclusions, created further confusion by making even stranger and mutually contradictory statements. 'Lalleshwari's association with Shah Hamadan", writes Bamzai, "was due to an identity of the faith of Sufis and Hindu mendicants and saints in Kashmir", adding that "the order she founded was an admixture of the non-dualistic philosophy of Shaivism and Islamic Sufism". One is at a loss to understand what one can make of such pronouncements which have nothing to do with history or facts of Lal Ded's life. In what way was "the faith of the Hindu mendicants and saints of Kashmir" different from that followed by the general mass of the people ? And which religious or philosophical order was founded by Lal Ded? The word "admixture" leaves one stumped, but even before one recovers one finds him saying in the same breath that Shaivism, "the dominant religion of the time", was "ossified into a set of complicated rituals". Did the "Hindu mendicants", he refers to follow any other religion then?

Dr. R.K. Parmu is even more sweeping in his statements, blissfully ignorant of how they contradict each other. Branding the entire Hindu society of Lal Ded's time as "corrupt", he tells us that "Lal Ded preached against the Shaiva religion as it was practiced by the Tantric gurus of those times". Did she really? And who were these "Tantric gurus" any way?. But wait, Dr. Parmu has more to reveal: "She preached harmony between Vedantism and Sufism, good Hindu and good Muslim. What are the sources that he and Bamzai rely upon to make such pronouncements? Which of Lal Ded's vaakhs testifies to this? Or, which historical source? Or can just whims and notions replace historical investigation?

Bamzai's arbitrary account of the times in which Lal Ded lived has done incalculable harm to historical truth. If he is to be believed, the "pious lives" that Sufi saints of that period lived had the Hindus so charmed that they decided to embrace Islam en masse ! Of course, by implication all other led impious lives. Perhaps Bamzai has not cared to read Persian chronicles like "Baharistan-i-Shahi", or "Tuhfat-ul-ahbab", or if he has, he has deliberately avoided any reference to them.

There are several verses of Lal Ded in which she refers to her attainment of self-realization and spiritual enlightenment. For her it is a real experience of life. There is no shadow of doubt or uncertainty about it in her mind. And, what is more, there is a tone of tremendous self-confidence and assurance in her verses when she tells us about her mystical illumination. As, for instance, in these lines:

Samsaras ayas tapasi
Bodhu prakashu lobum sahaj
 Into this universe of birth I came
 By Yoga gained the self revealing light !
 (Trans. Nila Cram Cook)

Loluki naru vaalinj buzum
shankar lobum tami suuty
 My heart I parched as farmers parch the grain
 And from that fire there came a wondrous boon
 And Shiva in a flash I did obtain
 (Trs. Nila Cram Cook)

lal bo tsayas swaman bagu baras
vuchhum shivas shakath milth tu vah
tati lay karum arnrit saras
zinday maras tu karyam kyah
 I, Lalla, entered through the door of the garden
 of my mind
 And saw Shiva and Shakti united into one, O
 joy!
 There I became immersed in the lake of nectar
 And died even while I was still alive
 What will now death do unto me ?

adu lali mye praavum param gath
 And then I, Lalla, attained the supreme state.

And if that is the case, why hasn't anyone asked so far what need had Lal Ded to go to a Sayyid Hamadani or a Sayyid Samnani, or anyone else for that matter, to become his "murid-e-khas"? You cannot disregard or dilute the Shaiva metaphysical content in her thought by harping on such stories and fabrications. The secret of her phenomenal popularity, even during her own lifetime, was the great spiritual heights she had attained and this greatness sometimes gave her courage to even question her own Guru:

gwaras pritshyom sasi late
yas nu kenh vanan tas kyah nav
pritshan pritshan thachis tu lusur
kenhas nishi kyah tany drav
 A thousand times did I my Guru ask
 What is the name of the one who can't be
 named
 And asking again and again I tired myself out
 How has something come out of nothing?

One cannot imagine how someone like her could have submitted meekly before the Sayyid missionaries at the fag end of her life and agree to give up her life long faith? Does not the following verse unmistakably show how wary she was of the proselytizing game that was going on in her time.

ha tsyatta kava chhuy logmut par mas
kavu goy apuzis pazyuk bronth
dushi boz vash kornakh para dharmas ...
 O mind, why do you feel intoxicated by
 someone else's wine?
 Why do you mistake the unreal for the real?
 Weak mindedness has let you to be overcome
 by others' faith.

In another vaakh, Lal Ded says of herself: "Lalla merged herself in the light of pure consciousness (chitta jyoti) by means of the mysterious syllable Om, and thus did away with the fear of death". There is no place in Islam, in which God and Man have only a master-servant

relationship, for identification with the Supreme. Nor do orthodox Sufi order entertain such thought. Mansur had to pay with his life for saying "ana'I haq" (I am Truth).

What then is the source of Lal Ded's mysticism? Where from does it derive if not from Sufism? Prof. Jaya Lal Kaul and Prof. B.N. Parimu have very clearly shown how the Shiva philosophy of Kashmir forms the basis of her thought. "As I find", writes Prof. Kaul, "there is a remarkable correspondence between the experience of Lal Ded as given in Lalla Vaakh and that of Shaiva Siddhas as related in their Trikastrasas... This should undeniably prove that she was a Shaiva Yogini, not only because she uses, whenever she needs to use them, the technical terms only of Tiika Darshana but, more so, because of her concept of God, her Yoga technique her own anubhava, direct perception and experience - all these are of Trika system." Prof. Parimu is equally specific: "The key to Lalla's mysticism is the Shivadvaita or the Trika philosophy of Kashmir". The mystic strain that is so prominent in Lal Ded's poetry, in fact, combines her quest for gnostic illumination with the depth of emotional experience. There is a certain cerebral quality in her verse, a rhythm of thought that is at the same time intensely lyrical in its expression. In his book "Triadic Mysticism", Paul E. Murphy calls her the "chief exponent of devotional or emotion-oriented Triadism". He writes: "Three significant representatives of devotionalism emerged in Kashmir in the five hundred years between the last half of the ninth and the end of the fourteenth centuries, they were : Bhatta Narayana, Utpaldeva and Lalla. Predominant in all three is the advocacy of a path of love unencumbered by techniques and means."

Bhatta Narayana, the direct disciple of Vasugupta, wrote the Stava Chintamani in the 9th century. The work, which Murphy calls "a love poem", has 120 verses on the communion between Shiva and Shakti "under the form of Prakasha and Vimarsha or Light and Self-Awareness". Utpala, who according to Lilian Silburn was "both mystic and genius, powerful

metaphysician, astute psychologist and above all, great poet", and "next to Abhinavagupta the most notable and audacious figure of the Self-Awareness {patibhijna} School", wrote Shiva Stotravali, described by Murphy as "the most beautiful of Shaiva love songs written in an intensely touching though simple style". Lal Ded, whose verses record her own mystic life, shares with these two Shaiva poets, who preceded her, a sharp feeling of the immediate presence of Shiva, the Divine Being. The poetry of all the three of them stems from "an intense resignation to the divine will", and reflects their vivacity, originality and deep sincerity. There is a striking similarity in many passages of theirs which can be compared for their "emotions, intoxications and sufferings", and the metaphors and images that express these. For instance, Utpala in his mystic ardour and with a mind inflamed by powerful longing approaches Shiva, the compassionate Lord, to attain communion with him and clenches Him with an impassioned cry and "holds Him in his fist":

"Here you are, I hold you in my fist! Here You are, I've seen You-where are You fleeing?"

[Stavachintamani, Tn. Paul E. Murphy]

This has a perfect parallel in Lalla, who evokes the same image in this expression of hers:

*andryum prakash nyabar tshot um
gati rot um tu karmas thaph!*

I diffused outside the light that lit-up within me
And in that darkness I seized Him and held Him tight!

Images and metaphors relating to the concept of Shiva's self-luminosity abound in Shaiva devotional poets, and the Bata or "darkness" that Lal Ded refers to is the dark Mystical Night of anguish and suffering which ultimately leads to the Night of Undifferentiatedness.

Bhatta Narayana uses the image of the dark cavern of heart where "darkness is dissipated on all sides by the Brightness Supreme". Here too there is a striking similarity in the words "the

interior cavern" used by Bhatta Narayana and "andryum" the "inner" (light) that Lal Ded has used.

Lala Ded expresses her mystical feelings-the pangs of separation from Shiva, the passionate urge to unite with Him, the desperate quest and the frustration of losing the direction, the difficulties of the path, the intensity of suffering which only strengthens her determination to seem Him face to face and possess Him, the total surrender of will and the ecstasy of the final beatitude-in imager and metaphors that are powerful and stunningly beautiful:

*lal bo drayas lolare
tshandan lustum dyan kyoh rath
vuchhum pandith panini gare
suy mye rotum nechhatur tu sath*
I, Lalla, set out with burning longing
And seeking, searching, passed the day and night
Till lo! I saw to mine own house belonging
The Pandit, and siezed my luck and star of light
(Trs. Nila Cram Cook)

*lal bo lusus tshandan tu gvaran
hal mye kormas rasani shyatiy
vuchhun hyotmas taary dithmas baran
mye ti kal ganeyi tu zogmas tatiy*
I, Lalla wearied myself searching and seeking
Exhausting my strength my every nerve as I
looked for Him,
I found His doors slammed and bolted
My longing became all the more intense
And I stood there watching for Him.

*ayas vate gayas nu vate
semanzu svathe lustum doh
chandas wuchhum har na ate
navi taras dimu kyah bo*
I came by the highway, but by the highway I did return
I found myself stranded halfway on the embankment
With the light of the day having faded away
Searching my pockets, a penny I did not find

What shall I pay now for being ferried across?

*mal wondi zolum
jigar morum
tyeli lal nav dram
yell dally traavymas tatiy*
I burned the impurities of the mind
And killed my desires
Then only I did my name Lalla became known
When I surrendered completely before Him

*panas laagith ruduk mye tsu
mye tsye tshandan lustum doh
panas manz yeli dyuthukh mye tsu
mye tse tu panas dyutLim tshoh*
In seeking 'me' and Thee' I passed the day
Absorbed within Thyself thou hadst remained
Concealed from me! I wondered for away
When I beheld Thee in myself, I gained
For Thee and me that rapure unrestrained
(Trs. Nila Cram Cook)

*pot zuni wathith mot bolanavum
dag lalunaavum dayi sunzi praye
lalu lulu karith lalu vuzunovunum
milith tas man shrotsyom dehe*
Waking up at the end of moonlit night
I called the 'mad one'-my mind
And soothed his pain with the love of God
Crying "It is I Lalla, it is I Lalla", I awakened the Beloved
And by becoming one with Him my mind and body became pure!

The first step in this "mystical progression" is, according to Silvia Silburn, self-annihilation or destruction of all doubt and dualism, and the culmination is communion with the divine, which in Shaiva triadic terminology is self-realization of one's Shiva-nature, a stage in which nothing remains but Shiva-consciousness-"soruy suy to boh no kenh" (He is everything, and I am nothing). The ultimate mystical selfrealization in Lal Ded, therefore, means absorption in Shiva.

But Lal Ded does not remain hovering in the high heaven of mystic experience alone. She has her feet firmly planted on the earth. There is no tendency in her to separate the experiences of mystical life from the experiences of ordinary life. Instead of disregarding everyday experiences she elevated herself through it to the ultimate experience of liberation, which in Trika metaphysics means swatantrya or absolute freedom of will, which is the nature of Supreme Shiva Himself. Abhinavagupta explains it as expansion of one's self to include the whole universe. Kashmir Shaivism, it should be noted, does not reject the phenomenal world as unreal or illusory but regards it to be the self-expression of Shiva-His poem, His work of art, His projection of Himself on a screen which is also Shiva. Lal Ded's expression of her longing to attain oneness with transcendence, therefore, should be taken to mean expression of her feeling of unity with Shiva's immanent form also. If "Shiva is all", then to her, He is not different from the ordinary man we find on the streets-he who laughs and sneezes and coughs and yawns:

*ase paande zvase zame
nyathuy snan kari tirthan
vahri vahras nonuy ase
nishi chhuy tu parzantan*

Yes, He it is who laughs and coughs and yawns
He, the ascetic naked all the year
Who bathes in sacred pools in all the dawns
But recognise how He to you is near
(Trs. Nila Cram Cook)

For Lal Ded, there is no difference between the 'I' and the 'other' ("par to pan"), immanence and transcendence, universal and individual consciousness-subjective and objective reality being but aspects of the ultimate reality which is one and indivisible. She sees life as an eternal and continuous flow of consciousness:

*asi aasy tu aasi asu, asav
asi dor kar patuvath
shivas sori nu zyon tu marun
ravas sori nu atugath
We have been in the past*

In future also we shall be
Forever the sun rises and sets
Forever Shiva creates and dissolves and creates again.

It is not that she is talking in riddles or in paradoxes about cycle of births and re-births and immortality of the soul. She is talking of human life which is a stream that flows onwards and onwards. It is this experience of reality that is at the core of her mysticism, which begins as the quest for the ultimate and culminates in a vision that is profoundly humanistic. And this is what marks her as a great poet. Lal Ded is not a professional philosopher, nor her verses any philosophical treatise, but she is deeply concerned with the predicament and ultimate destiny of humankind.

Yet Lal Ded's poetry is not the poetry of social concern in the sense it is made out to be by some scholars. In their eagerness to construct her image as some sort of a social reformer out to reform the medieval Kashmiri society and rid it of the evils afflicting it. This is again a false image, a deliberate twist given to her spiritual humanism to suit ideological considerations. There is no use digging for communitarian ideals from her verses, for they are just not there, though she does feel disturbed by social injustice and discrimination of which she herself is a victim, and is outraged by the sham and pretence that go in the name of religion. She also displays a deep sensitivity towards human suffering, her heart bleeding at the sight of the learned man dying of starvation while an utter fool beats his cook (for not having cooked a tasty dish):

*gatulah akh vuchhun bochhi suuty maran
pan zan haran puhuni vavu lah
nyash bod akh vuchhum vazas maran
tanu lal bo praran tshenyam na prah
I saw a learned man dying of hunger
Trembling like dried leaves falling in harsh
winter wind
An utter fool I saw beating his cook
(For not having prepared a delicious dish)*

Since then I am waiting for being free of worldly attachments.

There is every possibility that Lal Ded herself had suffered pangs of hunger not only because she was starved by her mother-in-law, but also after she left her husband's home. This is what this verse seems to suggest:

*tsal tsetta vondas bhay mo bhar
chaany tsyanth karan panu anad
tse ko zanuni kshod hari kar
kival tasunduy toruk nad*
O, restless mind! Do not fear
The one who is Beginningless takes care of you
You do not know when he will satiate your hunger
Cry to Him alone for help!

In another verse she says:

*treshi, bwachhi ma kreshanavun
yany tshei tany sandarun dih*
Do not torment your body with the pangs of
durst and hunger
Whenever it feels exhausted, take care of it.

It should be obvious, therefore, that Lal Ded is not unaware of the harsh realities of life like hunger and poverty, nor ignorant of the agony and anguish of existence. Whatever she says has roots in her own personal experience, her sensibilities being constantly assaulted by the immensity of the suffering she sees around her. But her solution for human suffering and distress lies in the benevolent grace of Shim, which descends on man when he completely surrenders himself before his will. The intensity of her social awareness turns her almost into a rebel, even as her egalitarian ideas and ideals find expression in spiritual terms. Shiva, she says in one of her verses, shines like the sun on the high and the low alike:

*rav matu thali thali taapitan
taapitan uttam-uttam dish
varun matu lotu garu atsytyan
shiv chhuy kruth tu tsen vopadish*
Does the sun not shine everywhere alike

Or does it shine only on the best places?
Does not the water god "Varuna" enter every home?
Or does it enter only the homes of the fortunate?

While the way she asks such disturbing questions does reveal how intricately and intimately her spirituality is linked with her universal humanistic concerns, it would be too much to assume that she was actually a social activist. Yet there are people who like to persist with the theory that Lal Ded "synthesized the best" in Shaivite and Islamic traditions, whatever that may mean. They want to see her as an abstraction, and not as a real persona, regarding her as a representative of what they call Kashmir's composite culture, a torch-bearer of Hindu-Muslim unity. With obvious political motivations, they project her as though she were a spokesperson of the present day secular discourse and utilize her for scoring points in current political debates, not caring to think how cliched their arguments based on false premises have now become. Through their oversimplifications and vague generalizations, they have turned Lal Ded virtually into a one-verse poet, stripping her of her real glories, "Shiv chhuy thali-thali rozan, mav zan hyond to musulman" (Shiva abides in everything, so do not discriminate between a Hindu and a Musalman). Is that then the quintessence of her poetic thought? The only basis of her greatness? The verse appears to be a spurious one, although Rajanaka Bhaskara has included it in his collection of "Lalavakyani". Lal Ded had spent her early youth in the reign of Udyan Deva, the last Hindu king of Kashmir, and of queen Kota Rani. Even when Islamic rule was finally established in 1359 A.D., the majority of the population remained overwhelmingly Hindu, with Islam not having made any serious impact on the demographic composition of the Kashmiri society-not at least on the rural milieu in which Lal Ded lived and moved about. To whom then has the verse been addressed? Who was discriminating against whom? The fact is that attempts to show Lal Ded's verses as a part of the current secular debate, are being made only as a strategy to condone the barbarities

inflicted on Kashmiri Hindus during the six hundred years of Islamic rule. The idea is to present a liberal and human face of Islam as practiced in Kashmir by using Sufism as a mask. Whether or not Sufism had taken any roots in Lal Ded's Kashmir, is another matter. The strategy seems to have worked, for a general impression has been created that she was either a Sufi mystic herself or was deeply influenced by Sufism.

Whether or not Lal Ded had a social reformer's zeal, she was strongly egalitarian in her views and was more aware than most devotional poets about the prevailing social conditions of her times. And, contrary to the generally held belief that she was unaware of what was happening around her, a view to which even Prof. Kaul subscribes, there is enough evidence in Lalla's *vaaks* to show that she was very much conscious of what was going on around her, including the sweeping political changes that were taking place during her time. This is at least what the following lines of hers appear to suggest:

*hyath karith rajya pheri na
dith karith tripti na man*

In ruling kingdoms there is no relief
In giving them away there yet is grief
(Trs. Nila Cram Cook)

Is she not referring here to the Kota Rani-Rinchin Shah Mir affair that eventually brought in Muslim rule to Kashmir?

Lal Ded is scathing in her attack on hollow ceremony and ritual in religion, her emphasis being on inner experience. She has no belief in "sacred places and sacred times", pilgrimages and fasts supposed to bring religious merit. She scoffs at what A.K. Ramanujam calls "orthodox ritual genuflections" and recitations. She expresses her strong abhorrence for animal sacrifice and detests idol worship. She must have surely provoked the orthodoxy at whom she misses no chance to take pot-shots. In this she reminds one of the Kannada Vachana poet Basavanna, and also of Kabir and Nanak whom

she anticipated. Surely, hers was a strong voice of protest in medieval Kashmir-perhaps the only voice raised so fearlessly.

With Lal Ded not conforming to any of the image constructs built around her by those who want to reduce her to an idea or an abstraction according to their predilections, what could the real Lal Ded have been like? To reclaim her authentic persona, we have no option but to discard the motivated myths and invoke the actual text of her verses. In this context, it must be noted that Lal Ded recited her *vaaks* to actual audiences who were enraptured and mesmerized by her words, which happened to be in their own mother tongue. In verse after verse we find her addressing the ubiquitous Bhatta, whether to admonish him (*puz kas karakh hutu bata – 'Who will you worship, O ritual-ridden Pundit?'*), or to explaining a subtle point or two (*yohoy vopdish chhuy bata – 'This is what the doctrine teaches, O Pundit!'*). This clearly shows that she knows her audience. Not that Lal Ded belongs to any one community-her message is certainly universal-but she does have the Pandit in mind whenever she has a point to make.

To find out the authentic Lal Ded, then, we have to rely mainly on the internal evidence that her *vaaks* furnish. Packed with sufficient biographical material, as the *vaaks* are, we can reconstruct with their help her mystic life, her experience as a woman, as a saint and as a poet, her view of the relationship between God, man and the world. An image as near reality as possible. But in this there are problems. Lalla *vaaks* have been orally transmitted from generation to generation and are available only in randomly available versions, with practically no chronological sequence. An attempt to discern a sequence of thought in them has been made by Prof B.N. Parimoo, who has tried to link them as thematic units under some broad divisions in his book, "The Ascent of Self". The book, written in 1978, is the first exercise of its kind undertaken by anyone and can be deservedly called a significant contribution to Lal Ded studies. "The cue to the arrangement of the verses", says the author, "is taken from the

'I-ness' categorically denoting personal experience".

But admirable as Prof. Parimoo's attempt to "re-interpret" the vaakhs is, one cannot be certain that while picking up the autobiographical threads he has arranged them according to actual chronological sequence, that is, exactly in the order they were composed. Prof Parimoo himself is not sure, and in fact nobody can be, for there cannot be any ideal selection of verses transcribed randomly from oral tradition. The author of the book, however, does not appear to have taken as much care as he should have in making his selection. Quite a number of verses he has included are obvious interpolations. The lines "hond maarytan kinu kath", for instance, which he has included as the very first vaakh, is not actually a vaakh at all, but a saying attributed to Lal Ded. His total reliance on the account of Ramjoo Malla for biographical information because it does not "tilt the purpose of this book" appears to be rather curious.

Before referring to the text, therefore, we have to be sure how far genuine it is. This accentuates the need of a critically valid text of Lalla Vaaks-something that has not been attempted quite seriously so far, except a solitary attempt made by Prof. Jaya Lal Kaul. Laments Prof. Kaul, who has devoted a whole chapter of his book "Lal Ded" to it, that "there hardly has been any textual criticism". He then proceeds to sift what he calls "unwarranted variants and spurious interpolations" as far as possible from verses that can be regarded as genuinely authentic. Of the total 258 vaakhs that circulate in the name of Lal Ded and occur in various collections, he has included only 138 in his collection and even their authenticity he is not prepared to "vouch for". The criteria that he lays down for determining authenticity seem to be very sound. These according to him should be: "The evidence of diction and prosody, and the quality and cast of thought, the way it is organized in the process of expression, in a word, the characteristic style of Lal Ded". To this I would like to add that both the text and

context should be taken into consideration, as well as the overall feeling tone of the verses.

Prof. Kaul has pointed out : "There are 35 verses that occur both in ... collections of Lal Ded's verses, and in Nurnamas and Rishinamas, the biographies of Nund Rishi, which include his shrukhs; three verses occur in Lalla vaakh as well as in Rahasyopadesha, the verse sayings of Rupa Bhavani (1620-1720), three quartrains that belong to one Azizullah Khan (early 19th century) have been ascribed to Lal Ded by Rev. J. Hinton Knowles in his Dictionary of Kashmiri Proverbs". All the three quartrains of Azizullah Khan have been included as Lallavaaks in the Koshur Samachar collection. Interestingly, one of these quartrains has been translated by that great Indian translator A.K. Ramanujan in the name of Lal Ded, and quoted as such by K. Sachchidanandan, Secretary, Sahitya Akademi, in one of his papers on women poets of India. The verse, as given in the Lal Ded Number of Koshur Samachar is as follows:

*daman basti dito dam
thitay yithu daman khar
shastras swan gatshi haasil
wuni chhay sul tu tshandun yar*

Obviously, neither the diction (she could never have used words like 'yaar' or 'haksil') nor the quality and cast of thought of this verse is that of Lal Ded, but it continues to be ascribed to her again and again. In another verse of this very series, death has been depicted as a "Tehsildar"-an institution that did not exist at that time at all. The confusion prevailing in this regard is mainly due to interpolations, a game indulged in by many, not without a strong element of deliberateness. Lines from other poets heavily laden with Persian and Arabic words have been passed on as Lal Ded's as in an attempt at what can be called linguistic subversion. Some of her ardent and overzealous admirers too have tried to put words in her mouth, though out of reverence for her. The total incompatibility of diction seems to have never bothered the perpetrators of such distortions. Yet nobody can

claim that the language in which Lallavaakhs have been passed on to the unsuspecting inheritors of her oral legacy is the language in which they must have originally fallen from the celebrated poetess' mouth. The only sure way to ascertain their authenticity would be a linguistic comparison with extant Kashmiri works of periods immediately preceding or succeeding Lal Ded, as written evidence of no contemporary work is available. These works are the 'Chhumma Sampradaya' verses which can be assigned to the 11th or 12th century, 'Mahanaya Prakasha' by Shiti Kantha, 'Banasur Katha' by Avtar Bhatta and 'Sukha-dukha Charit' by Ganak Prashast. I had the good fortune of studying all these works while preparing my doctoral thesis on the linguistic peculiarities of 'Banasura Katha', and so I am aware of their significance in presenting a somewhat coherent picture of the medieval development of the Kashmiri language and their immense value in tracing earlier forms of a good number of Kashmiri words. These works provide ample evidence of the fact that Kashmiri has developed from the MIA stages of Prakrit and Apabhramsha in the same way as other Indo-Aryan languages have. Anyone who cares to go through these works will be able to gain valuable knowledge of the linguistic situation that actually prevailed in Kashmir from the 11th-12th century to the end of the 15th. It would be useful to give here one example each from the above mentioned works to give a feel of the state of Kashmiri language used during this period:-

*bhava svabhava saba avinashi
sapana sabhava vi uppanna
te az niravidihi agam prakashi
idassa dishti kachi vipachhanna*
(Chumma Sampradaya)

*yasu-yasu jantus samvid yas-yas
nila pita sukha-dukha-swarup
udayis datta samanyi samaras
kama kampana tas-tas anurup*
(Mahanaya Prakasha)

*dhik-dhik myaanis yadava zammas
vanati atsa majja kachan
yudha kara namet swakammas
ushe atha chhon iha than*
(Banasura Katha)

*him zan tape viglyos pape
kukaram chitto*
(Sukha-dukha Charit)

A detailed description of the linguistic features of these works is not possible here; but one can clearly notice the thread of linguistic development that runs through them. Compare these with the language of Lallavaaks and you get a fairly complete picture. Grierson has called the language of Lal Ded's vaakhs "Old Kashmiri", but it does not require any special insight to see that it is quite "modern" compared to the language of the illustrations cited above because of the many changes it has undergone due to oral transmission. However, we can come as near to an authorized version as possible by reconstructing their text with the help of Banasur Katha and Sukh-dukha Charit. This is a desirable but extremely difficult task.

Even so, those who take the deliberately distorted and mutilated text to be genuine, ignoring the fact of its massive interpolation, must know that Lal Ded could in no case have used the heavily Persianised language of the 19th or early 20th century nearly six hundred years back. It is of utmost importance therefore, that to arrive at authentic Lal Ded, we should discard all the spurious elements introduced by those who are interested in building false image constructs.

Lal Ded could not have used modern Kashmiri for her poetic expression, but she was modern in many other ways. She had in her the characteristic modern self-reflectiveness, the insistence on accepting as authentic only what she herself could experience directly, the broad catholicity of outlook that called for tolerance of diverse views and made her define her

relationship to God in terms of oneness of all existence, the deep existential anguish she felt while reflecting on the human condition. She was modern in the universality of her concerns, in her choice of metaphor and image, in her rejection of every kind of sham and pretence, in her fearless assertion of what she saw as truth. Indeed, at times it appears that she is more modern than most of the contemporary Kashmiri poets.

Lal Ded's struggle as a woman has been largely overlooked. She may not have been a conscious feminist in the sense the term is understood today, but she did show the courage of resisting the oppressive structures of patriarchy and refusing to play the traditional role of a submissive daughter-in-law. Rebelling against social tyranny, she broke the shackles that bind a woman even before her birth, and asserted her right of taking her own decisions. She challenged the orthodoxy and threw the rigid codes of dress and decorum followed by the medieval society of her times to the winds and roamed about with barely any clothes on like the great Kannada Shaivite poetess, Mahadeviakka. Perhaps it was her last act of defiance against a social set-up whose arbitrary and gender discriminatory rules she did not find acceptable.

It is in accordance with these facts that we shall have to reconstruct the image of the great saint-poetess of Kashmir, noting that she does not fit into most of the image-constructs that have been built around her. The Shah Hamadan anecdote and the so-called miracle of the oven seem to be an insult to such a fearlessly and fiercely independent woman. She started her spiritual journey as a tormented soul, but attained a stage where self-realization and self-awareness gave her tremendous inner strength and the confidence that derived from that strength:

kesari vanu volum ratith shal

I dragged the lion from its den like a jackal.

It is this that explains the pervasive influence that Lal Ded has on Kashmiri psyche to this

day. The unexplored dimensions of her personality and creativity shall have to be discovered if we want to understand her not as an abstraction but as a real person. She is quintessentially Kashmiri, having shaped the Kashmiri language and literature, as she did, but she is also universal in her appeal. Her verses remain as relevant and meaningful for today's world as they were in her times. Let me conclude by quoting a line from one of her own most powerful *vaaks*:

yim pad lali vany tim hridi ank

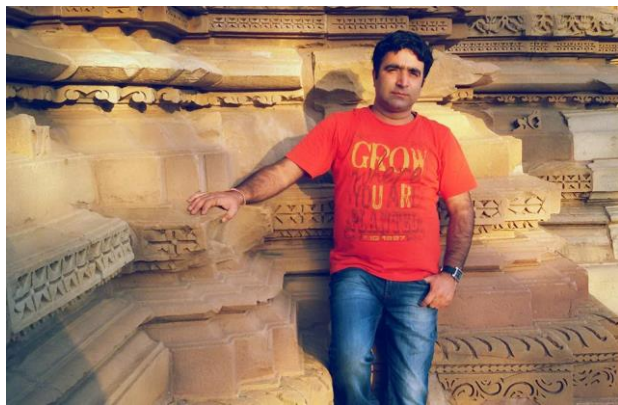
Brand on your heart what Lalla spoke in verse!

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(Dr. S.S Toshkhani is a poet, linguist, writer and a thinker. He has contributed substantially to Kashmiri heritage and carried out modern research in various fields of Kashmiri literature, history, religion, art and social sciences)



Subhash Kak is a Renaissance figure

Neeraj Santoshi Khar

My first brush with Subhash Kak was many years ago when I read his haiku poems in Hindi section of Koshur Samachar. They had the fragrance of Zen poems and reminded me of the poetry of Zen masters like Basho and Issa which I had read long back. I can still remember some of the poems, though I am bad at remembering poetry.



It was later that I came to know that this 58 year old Kashmiri Pandit in America not only writes soulful poetry but he has also made great contributions in information-theoretic aspects of quantum mechanics and worked on models of the brain from pattern processing point of view. Besides authoring over 200 journal papers, numerous essays, and fifteen books, his scientific contributions include one of the earliest patents on speech scrambling and a patent on instantaneously trained “neural networks”, which has found applications in time-series prediction and has also been used in the design of a meta-search engine.

But what fascinated me more was that this Scientist-Sanskrit scholar had made original contributions in our understanding of the ancient history of India, which has forced the historians to have a rethink on our ancient history. His researches have explored the

connectedness of Vedic and Vedantic ideas with the latest insights of modern physics and neurosciences. He made it known to the world that in certain fields like grammar and consciousness studies, our forefathers had made astonishing advances, which are yet to be understood fully by the people of this 21st century.

A mere look at the list and titles of his books will say much about his wide range of interests and depth of his researches. His books include **Patanjali and Cognitive Science (1987)**, **India at Century's (1994)**, **In Search of the Cradle of Civilization, (1995, 2001)**, **The Astronomical Code of the Rgveda (1994)**, **Computing Science in Ancient India (2001)**, **The Wishing Tree: The Presence and Promise of India (2001)**, **Gods Within: Mind, Consciousness and the Vedic Tradition (2002)**, **The Asvamedha: The Rite and Its Logic (2002)**, **The Nature of Physical Reality 1986**, **The Prajna Sutra (2003)**, **The Architecture of Knowledge: Quantum Mechanics, Neuroscience, Computers and Consciousness (2004)**, **Advances in Communications and Signal Processing (1989, with W.A. Porter)**, **Advances in Computing and Control (1989, with W.A. Porter and J.L. Aravena)**. His Poetry books include : **The Conductor of the Dead (1974)**, **The London Bridge (1977)** **The Secrets of Ishbar (1996)** **Ek Taal, Ek Darpan (1999)**, **The secrets of Ishbar: Poems on Kashmir and other landscapes, Vitasta (1996)**

I am also surprised that the so-called Pandit intelligentsia do not talk much about his work or invite him here for lectures and honour this great son of the soil. May be they are “busy in their politics and saving culture by just regularly popping out press statements.”

I must share with readers how I myself discovered “the wonderful world of Subhash Kak”. Some years ago, before having known much about Subhash Kak, I read some leaves from the autobiographical book **Autumn Leaves** of his father Ram Nath Kak, who had served at various places in Kashmir as a senior veterinary officer. I immensely liked its cover that features golden brown leaves of Chinar in autumn, which remind me of their husky smell and

my smell-associated childhood memories. Reading it, I felt as if a grandfatherly figure was telling his grandson in exile about his varied experiences of life, journeys to far off places in Kashmir and his own tale on various events. In the concluding part of the book, Ram Nath Kak mentions about his son, Subhash Kak whose interest in ancient India and research makes him feel a proud Kashmiri Pandit, a true son of soil who has continued the intellectual pursuits and quest for truth of our ancient seers like Abhnavagupta, Anandavardhana and synthesized ancient ideas with the cutting edge researches in modern science.

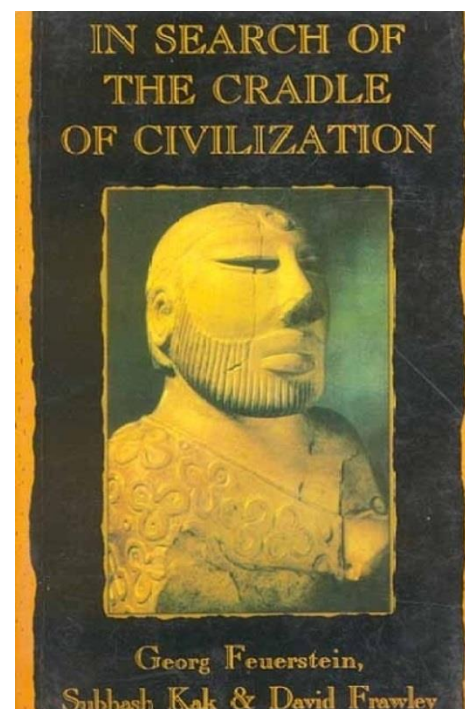
Later when I got net connection at home, I searched more about him in the cyberspace and found a wealth of information about him and his work. I downloaded most of his researches papers, which total about 400 pages on my PC and is almost a treasure house on ancient wisdom for me.

It may be mentioned here that Subhash Kak, born on March 26, 1947 in Srinagar, was educated in several schools in Jammu, Kashmir, and Ladakh, and obtained a degree in Electrical Engineering from the Jammu and Kashmir University in 1967, after which, he joined IIT Delhi and completed his Ph.D in 1970 on information and communications engineering. He has researched on cryptography, random sequences, coding, artificial intelligence, and neural networks. After working for a major period from 1970 to 1979, at IIT Delhi, with brief stints at Imperial College, University of London, Bell Laboratories, and Tata Institute of Fundamental Research, he finally moved to the Louisiana State University as a professor in 1979. Over the years, he became interested in the history of ancient science in India, early mathematics and linguistics.

This practicing electrical engineer wanted to be a writer in his school days, but it was his mother that persuaded him to join an engineering college. But later he had no regret on this account. On the contrary he found that literary and scientific arenas were not all that different. To me he truly represents the essence of a scientist and a mystic put together or a stage where there is not much difference between a scientist and a mystic

Kak's interest in ancient science developed when he delved into Panini's 2500-year-old grammar, a work of astonishing subtlety and depth. His study of the

ancient texts, made things clear to him and he announced to the world that the "paradigm in which ancient Indian history had been examined was wrong". His findings on ancient India has given "a centrality to India in world history".



His famous book with George Feuerstein and David Frawley, **In Search of the Cradle of Civilization**, emphasizes that India was the cradle of the very first civilization, not Sumer in Iraq or other civilization. He claims that India has had cultural continuity for at least 10,000 years and it was in India first that artistic, scientific, philosophical and religious impulses arose, giving India a sort of centrality in the history of mankind.

One of his most famous assertions is the suggestion that the modern computer science term for context-free languages, the Backus-Naur Form, should more accurately be called the Panini-Backus. Panini's 6th century BC grammar provides 4,000 rules that describe the Sanskrit of his day completely and is acknowledged to be one of the greatest intellectual achievements of all time

In his famous research paper on "**Panini's Grammar and Computer Science**", Subhash Kak says that his analysis was meant to highlight several formal features of Panini's grammar that have direct parallels in computer science, adding, "What might be other

features of the grammar that have not yet been rediscovered in computer science remains to be seen". Kak points out that the great variety of language mirrors, in many ways, the complexity of nature. "What is remarkable is that Panini set out to describe the entire grammar in terms of a finite number of rules. Frits Staal (1988) has shown that the grammar of Panini represents a universal grammatical and computing system. From this perspective it anticipates the logical framework of modern computers", he says. He further adds that these fundamental investigations that have bearing on linguistics, knowledge representation, and natural language processing by computer require collaboration between computer scientists and Sanskritists. He says that it would allow the Sanskrit departments to complement the programme of the computer science departments and hopes, that a graduate of Sanskrit could make useful contributions to the computer software industry as well, particularly in the fields of natural language processing and artificial intelligence. Kak has established that as per the cryptological analysis, the Brahmi script of the Mauryan times evolved out of the third millennium Sarasvati (Indus) script, which was perhaps the first true alphabetic script. He points out that the worship of Sarasvati as the Goddess of Learning remembers the development of writing on the banks of the Sarasvati river. He maintains that it appears that the symbol for zero was derived from the fish sign that stood for "ten" in Brahmi and this occurred around 50 BC to 50 AD. Besides, this he has also made major breakthroughs in deciphering the Indus script, on which he has worked for more than a decade.

On the intellectual arthritis of Indian scholars, he has a point to make. In an interview to the rediff.com in 1999, Subhash Kak says, **"It is only the India of the past fifty years that has turned its back on its own heritage and our scientists literally know nothing about our intellectual history, excepting the distorted second-hand accounts written by colonial historians and their Indian followers"**.

Stressing the wisdom of our seers, Subhash Kak points out that one of the greatest scientists of the 20th century, Erwin Schrodinger, was directly inspired by Vedanta in his creation of quantum mechanics, a theory at the basis of all our developments in most fields of science today including computers.

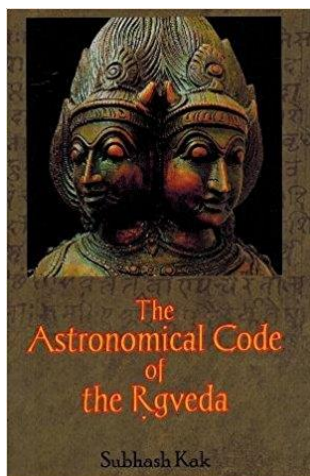
One of his major contributions is his startling discovery that the organization of the Rigveda was according to an astronomical code. He developed the key to unlock the ancient mystery of the Vedas, opening up a still unopened chapter of Indian science.

Kak has also worked on the Indus-Sarasvati Civilization and proved that the Sarasvati did in fact exist, and flowed down to the sea, parallel to the Indus, before a major earthquake in about 1900 BC separated its two tributaries, the Satluj and the Yamuna, which merged with Sindh and the Ganga. He reasons that after the economy around the Sarasvati river collapsed due to the drying up of the river, people moved to the east, northwest and to the south.

He also dared to announce that famous German indologist Max Muller was "absolutely wrong". He says that the Max Mueller chronology of the Vedas must be rejected and that the Rig Veda must be dated back not to 1500 BC, but to about 3000 BC.

Subhash Kak also argues against the Aryan Invasion theory, stressing that there is no evidence of a break in Indic tradition, going back to 10,000 years. He also argues that the Aryan-Dravidian divide simply doesn't exist, and that the superficial differences between North and South India are cosmetic and outcome 19th century's racist discourse.

One is amazed about the aspects of ancient life he has researched. Consider his research on the structure of the fire altars in scriptural ritual, which he has elaborated in his book **The Astronomical Code of the Rigveda**. He says that our rishis represented their astronomy in terms of the altar constructions. He emphasizes that our ancient seers were aware that the sun and the moon were at 108 times their own diameters from the earth., and this symbolism is reflected by the 108 beads of the rosary, symbolizing spiritual journey towards enlightenment.



In the book edited by him and Dr TRN Rao **Computing Science in Ancient India**, he talks about advances ancient Indians had made in mathematics . He talks about the value pi to many decimal places, Sayana's accurate calculation of the speed of light, hashing algorithms, the binary number system of Sanskrit meters, mathematical logic (Navya Nyaya), and adds in the same book that most advanced calculus, math and astronomy arose in Kerala several centuries before Newton.

Kak also points out that the 13th century AD scholar Sayana, prime minister at the court of the Vijayanagar Emperor Bukka I, calculated the speed of light to be 2,202 yojanas in half a nimesha, which surprisingly does come to 186,536 miles per second!

About his views on the Kashmir issue and Kashmiri Pandits, he says in an interview to Times Of India ,(dated Feb. 27th) **“Personally, I am for political movement in Kashmir, but I don't see how it can be made as long as Pakistan pushes in Afghan and Punjabi mercenaries into the valley for acts of terror. As a Kashmiri myself, I think the ethnic cleansing of the Kashmiri Hindus from the Valley and their continuing massacres by bands of terrorists is one of the horrors of modern times, to be equated to the massacre of the Armenians early in the last century in Turkey and that of the Jews and the Roma in Nazi Germany. I believe history will judge the West-- in particular Bill Clinton's presidency-- harshly for looking the other way while this horror has continued”**.

Even from thousands of miles I can feel his quest for his roots and ultimate home of truth. Perhaps that has led him to go deep

into ancient mysteries and has led him to translate Vasugupta's 8th century AD Shiv Sutras , the 78 aphorisms of Shiva in the modern idiom, making it more readable and understandable across the globe .

His quest for his roots is more deep than just academic and scholarly interest in Kashmir. In an article “This Side of Paradise”, published in one of the publications dated November 11, 2001, which I read online, he pours out his heart and questions his search in USA.

“The landscape of my childhood memories lay defiled and I sought a place for myself where I could be connected to new sacred ground. America, in spite of its vast spaces, lacked the sanctities that spring from the magic of childhood not merely one's own, but also of forefathers. Even more, America was the region of worldly contest. Now that war has come to the shores of America, its certainties appear naive, and the contest has lost its excitement. Strangely, after it has become like all other lands, I know why I didn't find the place I sought here. I couldn't find it because it lay all along in the world of my own heart”.

When I read these lines I was reminded of his father who died in Honolulu in 1993. In the last part of the Autumn Leaves his father says, **“ I cannot return to Kashmir to smell its air, to walk its bazaars. I recall that last time we were there I took Babuji on a shikara ride on the Dal Lake in moonlight and the beauty of the moment brought such a flood of memories to Babuji that he could not restrain his tears”**.

Today, his son Subash Kak may not be able return to Kashmir, but we are proud that he has kept its fragrance , its essence , its spirit alive in his heart and not only that, he spread it to the whole of the world.

(Neeraj Santoshi Khar is a journalist with Hindustan Times and is an avid reader and seeker of the philosophical knowledge)



Art and Cosmology in India

Prof. Subhash Kak

The best way to understand India is through its art and the cosmology. Textbook narratives often overlook the synthesizing principles that represent the grammar of Indian culture, and they are much like the accounts of the six blind people who encountering an elephant describe it as wall, spear, snake, tree, rope, and fan, respectively.

The three notions that underlie Indian culture are that of bandhu, paroksa, and yajña. Bandhu is the binding between the outer and the inner that makes it possible to know, and this is the basis of the pervasive spirituality in India; paroksa is the recognition that the bandhu must lie outside of rational system, leading to the distinction between the 'higher' science of consciousness and the 'lower', rational objective science; yajña is transformation that the individual undergoes by participating in Vedic 'ritual' or any other creative process. The cosmology related to this framework is that of infinity and recursion across scale and time.

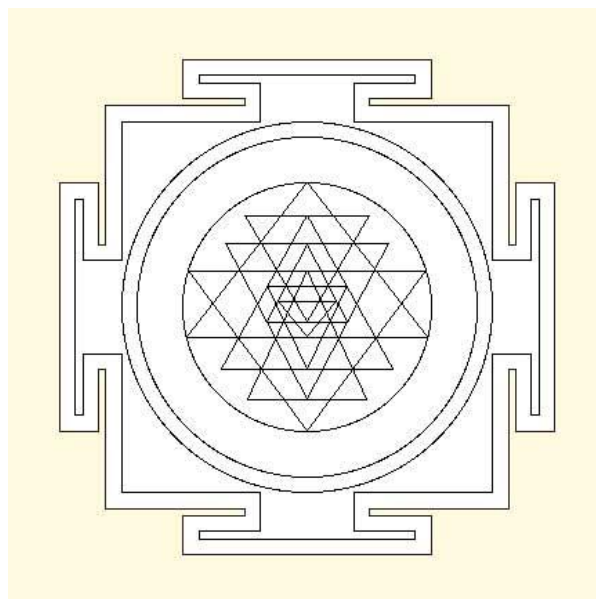


Figure 1. Sri Yantra, which represents the universe recursively

The iconic representation of the universe as the Sri Yantra (Figure 1) shows recursion most clearly. First, the tripartite division into earth, atmosphere, and the sun, which is mirrored in the individual by the body, the breath, and the inner lamp of consciousness, is represented by three triangles. Second, within each triangle are lower hierarchical levels of two other triangles, of alternating opposing polarity that represents male and female principles. All together, this adds up to 9 triangles, which through their overlaps constitute a total of 43 small triangles. Right through the middle of this is the dot, the bindu that is Shiva, the Witness, or Consciousness. Nature evolves according to law (rta in Sanskrit), but it has a paradoxical relationship with the consciousness principle.

Art associated with this conception must communicate recursion, paradox and oppositions concerning ordinary experience of the universe. Aesthetics, as a philosophy of art, is best understood from the point of view of dhvani, which communicates, by suggestion, the universals of the outer and inner worlds. Indian thought highlights the connections between these two worlds, and its art presents visions of the cosmos. Thus in

Figure 2, a north Indian temple, recursion is expressed in terms of the tower drawn to different scales on the superstructure.



Figure 2. A north Indian temple showing recursion in its outer structural form

Within the temple, the manifestations of the Supreme Being are as the One and its many forms. There exists in them, for example, a hierarchical order of cardinal and peripheral images in relation to the centre, a balancing or pairing of polarities, and representation of the temple as Mount Meru, the centre of the universe. The polarities represented iconographically related to female and male, asura (demon) and deva (god), left and right, body and mind, and so on. Aesthetics is alamkara shastra, that is ornamentation of the central synthesizing principle by means of the particular medium. The poet, kavi, is the inspired seer who sees the underlying vision most clearly. Dance, painting, and sculpture, just like poetry, have their canonical ideals, which are the visual equivalents of meter, rhyme, alliteration and the tropes of poetry.

The ritual is organized as sacred theatre that engages the senses to facilitate an epiphany that represents an experiential 'rebirth'. Great art has the same capacity, and often it is a part of ritual. Not only is the temple a work of art, so is the sculpture that goes into it, and the dance and music performed in its hallways, and the paintings that hang on its walls. One can contrast this with Western conceptions. The cosmology is finite, with God separate from the individual; art is best seen in the sterile atmosphere of the museum or the gallery.

General equivalences

The view that the arts belong to the domain of the sacred and that there is a connection between them is given most clearly in a famous passage in the Vishnudharmottara Purana in which the sage Markandeya instructs the king Vajra in the art of sculpture, teaching that to learn it one must first learn painting, dance, and music:

Vajra: How should I make the forms of gods so that the image may always manifest the deity?

Markandeya: He who does not know the canon of painting (citra sutram) can never know the canon of image-making (pratima lakshanam).

Vajra: Explain to me the canon of painting as one who knows the canon of painting knows the canon of image-making.

Markandeya: It is very difficult to know the canon of painting without the canon of dance (nritta shastra), for in both the world is to be represented.

Vajra: Explain to me the canon of dance and then you will speak about the canon of painting, for one who knows the practice of the canon of dance knows painting.

Markandeya: Dance is difficult to understand by one who is not acquainted with instrumental music (atodya).

Vajra: Speak about instrumental music and then you will speak about the canon of dance, because when the instrumental music is properly understood, one understands dance.

Markandeya: Without vocal music (gita) it is not possible to know instrumental music.

Vajra: Explain to me the canon of vocal music, because he, who knows the canon of vocal music, is the best of men who knows everything.

Markandeya: Vocal music is to be understood as subject to recitation that may be done in two ways, prose (gadya) and verse (padya). Verse is in many meters.

Some of the early meters range from the gayatri with 3 sections of 8 syllables ($3 \times 8 = 24$) to anushtubh ($4 \times 8 = 32$), viraj ($4 \times 10 = 40$), trishtubh ($4 \times 11 = 44$), and jagati ($4 \times 12 = 48$). These appear to be connected to the astronomical number 360, the number of civil days in the year. There are also many other more complex meters, with a less obvious astronomical basis.

To understand the principle behind the broader equivalences of Indian art and its cosmology, it is good to begin with the fire altars of the Vedic period that were themselves designed to represent astronomical (outer) as well as inner knowledge. An assumed equivalence between the outer and the inner cosmos is

central to the conception of the temple, which is why numbers such as 108 and 360 are important in its design.

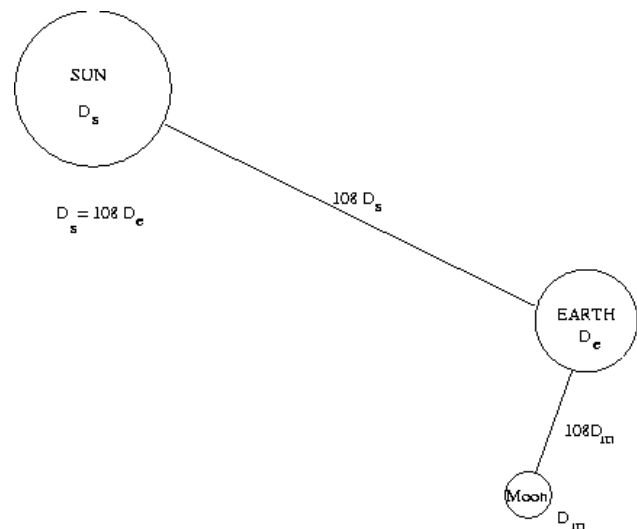


Figure 3. The number 108 in the distance from the earth to the sun and the moon

The number 108 represents the approximate distance from the earth to the sun and the moon in sun and moon diameters, respectively. (The diameter of the sun is also 108 times the diameter of the earth, but that fact is not likely to have been known to the Vedic rishis.) This number of dance poses (karanas) given in the Natya Shastra is also 108, as is the number of beads in a rosary (japamala). The 'distance' between the body and the inner sun is also taken to be 108, so that the number of joinings is 107. Not surprisingly, the number of marmas in Ayurveda is 107. The total number of syllables in the Rigveda is taken to be 432,000, a number related to 108.

The number 360 is taken in the Ayurvedic texts to be the number of bones in the developing fetus, a number that fuses later into the 206 bones of the adult. The centrality of this number in Vedic ritual is stressed in the Shatapatha Brahmana.

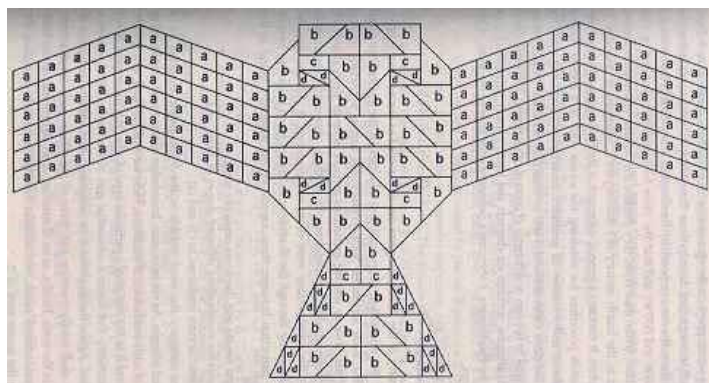
The primary Vedic number is three, representing the tripartite division of the physical world into the earth, the atmosphere,

and the sky and that of the person into the physical body, the pranas, and the inner sky.

The Vedic altars had an astronomical basis related to the reconciliation of the lunar and solar years, which mirrors the reconciliation of the female and male currents within the body and mind of the individual. The fire altars symbolized the universe and there were three types of altars representing the earth, the space and the sky. The altar for the earth was drawn as circular, whereas the sky (or heaven) altar was drawn as square.

The fire altars were surrounded by 360 enclosing stones, of these 21 were around the earth altar, 78 around the space altar and 261 around the sky altar. In other words, the earth, the space, and the sky are symbolically assigned the numbers 21, 78, and 261. Considering the earth/cosmos dichotomy, the two numbers are 21 and 339 since cosmos includes the space and the sky.

The main altar was built in five layers. The basic square shape was modified to several forms, such as falcon and turtle. These altars were built in five layers, of a thousand bricks of specified shapes. The construction of these altars required the solution to several geometric and algebraic problems.



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Two different kinds of bricks were used: the special and the ordinary. The total number of the special bricks used was 396, explained as

360 days of the year and the additional 36 days of the intercalary month. Two kinds of day counts: the solar day, and tithi, whose mean value is the lunar year divided into 360 parts.

Three different years were considered: (i) nakshatra, or a year of 324 days (sometimes 324 tithis) obtained by considering 12 months of 27 days each, where this 27 is the ideal number of days in a lunar month; (ii) lunar, which is a fraction more than 354 days (360 tithis); and (iii) solar, which is in excess of 365 days (between 371 and 372 tithis).

A well-known altar ritual says that altars should be constructed in a sequence of 95, with progressively increasing areas. The increase in the area, by one unit yearly, in building progressively larger fire altars is 48 tithis which is about equal to the intercalation required to make the nakshatra year in tithis equal to the solar year in tithis. But there is a residual excess which in 95 years adds up to 89 tithis; it appears that after this period such a correction was made. The 95 year cycle corresponds to the tropical year being equal to 365.24675 days. The cycles needed to harmonize various motions led to the concept of increasing periods and world ages.

The number of syllables in the Rigveda confirms the textual references that the book was to represent a symbolic altar. According to various early texts, the number of syllables in the Rigveda is 432,000, which is the number of muhurtas in forty years. In reality the syllable count is somewhat less because certain syllables are supposed to be left unspoken. The organization of the Rigveda is also according to a plan, but that is a different story told in my book *The Astronomical Code of the Rigveda*.

The verse count of the Rigveda can be viewed as the number of sky days in forty

years or $261 \times 40 = 10,440$, and the verse count of all the Vedas is $261 \times 78 = 20,358$.

The Brahmanas and the Shulbasutras tell us about the altar of chhandas and meters, so we would expect that the total Rigvedic hymn count of 1017 and the group count of 216 have particular significance. Owing to the pervasive tripartite ideology of the Vedic books we choose to view the hymn number as 339×3 . The tripartite ideology refers to the consideration of time in three divisions of past, present, and future and the consideration of space in the three divisions of the northern celestial hemisphere, the plane that is at right angle to the earth's axis, and the southern celestial hemisphere. The number 339 is simply the number of disks of the sun or the moon to measure the path across the sky: π times 108 is approximately 339. The Rigvedic code then expresses a fundamental connection between the numbers 339 and 108. The numbers 108 and 360 appear as the axis and the perimeter dimensions of the temple.

Temples and gods

The temple is considered in the image of the Cosmic Purusha, on whose body is displayed all creation in its materiality and movement. Paradoxically, the space of the Purusha (Rigveda 10.90) is in the sanctuary only ten fingers wide, although he pervades the earth.

The outer cosmos is expressed in terms of various connections between the temple structure and the motions of the sun, the moon, and the planets; the inner cosmos is represented in terms of the divinity (universal consciousness) in the womb of the temple and various levels of the superstructure that correspond to the states of consciousness. The position of the gods in the Vastupurusha-

mandala within the temple is a symbolic representation of the spatial projections of the cosmic Purusha in his body. There are other iconic representations of sacred space, as in the Sri Yantra where the body's three parts – vagbhava, madhya, and mula – have recursive structures within, that represent Vedic cosmology in a unique fashion.

The prototype of the temple is the Agnikshetra, the sacred ground on which the Vedic altars are built. The Agnikshetra is an oblong or trapezoidal area on which the fire altars are built. During the ritual is installed a golden disc (rukma) with 21 knobs or hangings representing the sun with a golden image of the purusha on it. The detailed ritual includes components that would now be termed Shaivite, Vaishnava, or Shakta. In Nachiketa Agni, 21 bricks of gold are placed one top of the other in a form of shivalinga. The disk of the rukma, which is placed in the navel of the altar on a lotus leaf is in correspondence to the lotus emanating from Vishnu's navel which holds the universe. Several bricks are named after goddesses, such as the seven krittikas.



Figure 5. Ganesha: elephant-headed, wise, with mouse as his vehicle

The Hindu temple represents the Meru mountain, the navel of the earth. It is the representation of the cosmos both at the level of the universe and the individual, making it possible for the devotee to get inspired to achieve his own spiritual transformation. The purusha placed within the brick structure of the altar represents the consciousness principle within the individual. It is like the relic within the stupa. The threshold to the inner sanctum is represented by the figure of Ganesha (Figure 5), who, like other divinities, symbolizes the transcendence of oppositions.

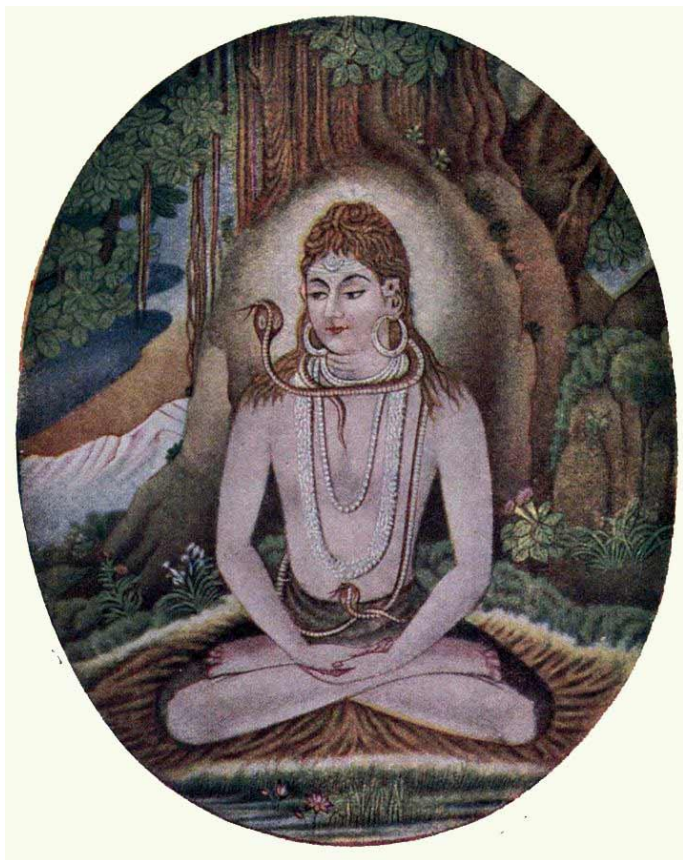
The temple construction begins with the Vastupurusha mandala, which is a yantra, mostly divided into 64 (8×8) or 81 (9×9) squares, which are the seats of 45 divinities. Brahma is at the centre, around him 12 squares represent the Adityas, and in the outer circle are 28 squares that represent the nakshatras. This mandala with its border is the place where the motions of the sun and the moon and the planets are reconciled. It is the Vastu in which the decrepit, old Chyavana of the Rigveda 1.116.10 asks his sons to put him down so that he would become young again. Chyavana is the moon and Sukanya, whom he desires, is the sun.

In the basic Vedic scheme the circle represents the earth and the square represents the heavens or the deity. But the altar or the temple, as a representation of the dynamism of the universe, requires a breaking of the symmetry of the square. As seen clearly in the agnichayana and other altar constructions, this is done in a variety of ways. Although the main altar might be square or its derivative, the overall sacred area is taken to be a departure from this shape. In particular, the temples to the goddess are drawn on a rectangular plan. In Shiva or Vishnu temples, which are square, change is represented by a play of diagonal lines. These diagonals are essentially kinetic

and are therefore representative of movement and stress. They embody the time-factor in a composition.

The Hindu temple, as a conception of the astronomical frame of the universe, serves the same purpose as the Vedic altar, which reconciled the motions of the sun and the moon. The progressive complexity of the classical temple was inevitable given an attempt to bring in the cycles of the planets and other ideas of the yugas into the scheme. There was also further complexity related to the expansion of the tattvas within the temple. For example, in Shaivite temples we see the unmanifest (Shivalinga) expand into the intermediate state of manifest-unmanifest (Sadashiva), and finally into manifest (Mahesha).

The Ashtadhyayi of Panini (5th century BC) mentions images. Ordinary images were called pratikriti and the images for worship were called archa. Amongst other things we are told that a toy horse is called ashvaka. (This means that the queen who lay down with the ashvaka in the Ashvamedha did not sleep with the dead horse.) Deity images for sale were called Shivaka etc., but an archa of Shiva was just called Shiva. Patanjali mentions Shiva and Skanda deities. There is also mention of the worship of Vasudeva (Krishna). We are also told that some images could be moved and some were immovable. Panini also says that an archa was not to be sold and that there were people (priests) who obtained their livelihood by taking care of it. They also mention temples that were called prasadas.



Shiva

Complementing the tradition of the Vedic ritual was that of the munis and yogis who lived in caves and performed austerities. From this tradition arose the vihara, where the priests lived. The chaitya hall that also housed the stupa may be seen as a development out of the agnichayana tradition where within the brick structure of the altar was buried the rukma and the golden man.

The gods are the entities that hold up the inner sky of the mind. There is the single Brahman or Purusha, interpenetrating and transcending the inner and the outer universes. But the framework of the inner sky is held up by a variety of gods. The physical nature, governed by laws, is the Goddess or Shakti. If Brahma is the deity of the astral world, Shiva is that of the physical world, and Vishnu that of the causal or the moral world. They each have a consort: Brahma's is Sarasvati, the goddess of learning and the arts; Shiva's is Parvati, the goddess of power,

energy, and intuition; Vishnu's is Lakshmi, the goddess of good fortune.

The gods themselves are interconnected. Brahma's origin is from the lotus in Vishnu's navel. Shiva is the god who subsumes all oppositions. He is the celibate, divine yogi, who is also the perfect husband to Parvati. He brings the world to an end by his dance, but he also creates the world. He is the heart of consciousness, the lord of all beings, the divine dancer. As Ardhanarishvara, he is half Shakti; as Harihara, he is half Vishnu.

Vishnu is the all-pervader, the primal person, without beginning or end. He is also known as Narayana, with his abode in the waters. He is Hari, the golden-garbed one (like the Sun), and his mount is Garuda, the eagle. During the periods in between dissolution and creation, he sleeps on the cosmic serpent Ananta (the endless). He wields in one of his hands the discus, Sudarshana, which represents time. His consort, Lakshmi, appeared out of the Churning of the Ocean. Periodically, he descends to earth as an avatara to battle evil. Two of the most popular of these avatars are Rama and Krishna.

Churning of the ocean

If extraordinary experience is an epiphany, it comes at the end of long preparation. In myth, we speak of the struggle between the asuras (demons) and the devas (gods), but this struggle also occurs within the individual between his materialistic and acquisitive tendencies that are demonic, and those of sacrifice, compassion, and understanding that are divine. This struggle is described as the churning of the ocean by the gods and the demons as in Figure 7. On the axis rests the Goddess, who represents Nature. Note that

the demons are shown with animal faces since they represent our animal selves.



Figure 7: The churning of the ocean

Our body sense is much stronger than the sense of spirit. It is for this reason the asuras are generally much stronger than the gods. The story goes that the gods have been defeated and they are dejected. At some point they go to Vishnu for help and he suggests that they should assist the asuras in the churning of the ocean of milk, out of which will appear the nectar of immortality that would help them subdue the asuras.

The gods and the demons got together and started churning the ocean with the Mount Mandara as the axis and the snake Vasuki as the rope. The gods were at Vasuki's tail while the demons were at his head. Vishnu appeared as a tortoise to support the revolving mountain. As the churning went on, many gifts appeared including the moon which Shiva decided to use as an ornament on his head. Next came Dhanvantari, carrying a jar full of nectar. Next arose Lakshmi, with her attendant elephants of the four quarters sitting on a lotus, a gift of the ocean. She went straight to Vishnu.

The demons were dismayed that Lakshmi had not come to them, and they stole the jar with the nectar that was in Dhanvantari's hands. But before they could drink it, Vishnu created an illusion of the most beautiful

woman, Mohini, and they were so bewitched by her that they did not notice that she took the cup from their hands and gave them to the gods to drink. By the time they knew what had happened the gods had become immortal. The demons drew their weapons and attacked but it was useless. The gods once again became rulers of the three worlds.



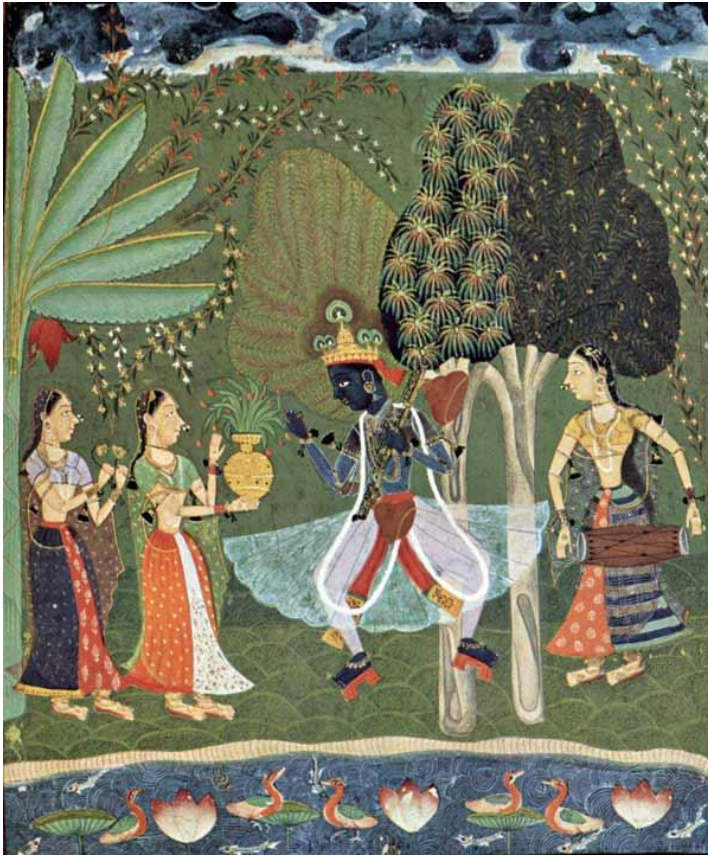
The asuric individual is doomed for he gets distracted by the illusory Mohini, whereas one who has higher ideals finds immortality and fame (Lakshmi).

Krishna's dance

Krishna's pranks and the love that the cowgirls (gopis) have for him is the frame for much of poetry, dance, and painting in India. As avatara of Vishnu, he is the narrator of the Vedic wisdom in the great dialogue of the Bhagavad Gita. His cowherd stories are a take-off on his other name Gopala, which means the protector of the world as well as cowherd, for the root gauh means both earth and cow.

The story of the love of the gopis is the story of each devotee for God. Krishna performs the rasa-lila, a dance, where mysteriously he is able to simultaneously dance with all the different gopis, which represents, no doubt,

the mystery that the same One is able to inhabit the many.



Dancing Krishna with his flute

Krishna, the flute player, is the spirit that inhabits each one of us. The flute is the body, and the melody is the unfolding of our individual lives. The love of Radha for Krishna can never be fulfilled, since the individual is forever doomed to stay apart from the divine in ordinary experience.

In the Mahabharata, Dhritarashtra is the ego, Vidura is discriminating intelligence, the Kauravas are the physical desires, Krishna is the transcending atman, Arjuna is the empirical atman; the higher faculties are the Pandavas, and the lower faculties are the Kauravas. The characters of the epics and the Puranas do not only act in the outer world; they play out our own private battles.

In the Ramayana, Sita is the intuition who has been abducted by the demon within, who

must be set free by Rama, the inner sun. The demon, representing the urge to dominate and possess, has ten heads that represent the sense and action organs of the body. In the struggle between the asuras and the gods, Hanuman, representing the human mind that has devotion, provides critical assistance.

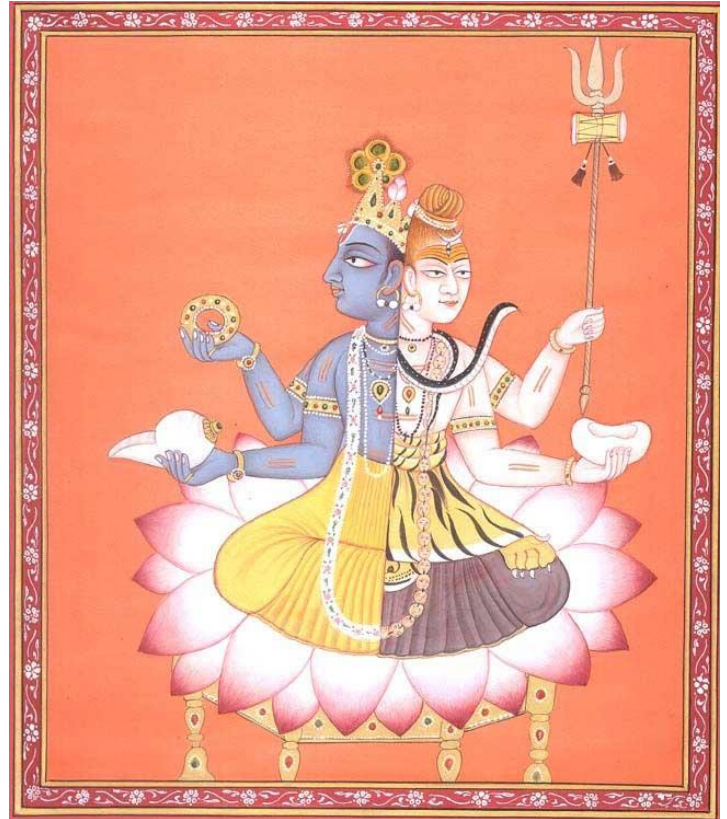


Figure 10. Harihara: Vishnu and Shiva as one

Although Vishnu and Shiva make their appearance generally in different situations since their centrality is in different domains, they are also visualized in a unity, as Harihara (Figure 10).

The Indian approach to reality is to seek a harmony that balances materiality with the spirit. It is this harmony that is the main goal of the artistic creation, and we see it expressed not only in the sacred arts, but also in music and dance.

The Indian aesthetic in an age of war

We live in an age of war fueled by conflicting visions of reality. The mainstream cultural view is of materialism in which consciousness is an emergent process and we are primarily nothing but our bodies. Perhaps because it belittles the spirit, it is leaving many young with a sense of hopelessness. If there is nothing transcendent about life, then life may not be worth living. While some are choosing drugs or hedonism, others are rejecting rationality and joining cults. Religious leaders are stepping in with their own recipes to save the world from a soul-less hell. But their conceptions contradict each other, and although they rightly critique the materialistic paradigm for its disconnect with the spirit, they themselves remain focused on the body when they speak of everlasting life in paradise.

Because of the mechanization of life and the expectations raised by images with which we are bombarded by the media, many are choosing not to have a family, leading to a demographic crisis in the developed world at a time when the post-industrial service economy needs more workers and consumers, requiring vast numbers of immigrants from poorer countries. These are some of the elements leading to a clash of civilizations.

The Indian way offers a different perspective. Indian cosmology is not in conflict with science, although it does speak of the domain of spirit that lies beyond language and rational science. It makes claims regarding the nature of consciousness and transcendent

states of awareness that are so extraordinary that if they should be validated by science, they would change the way we conceive of reality.

Our collective history in recent decades has tilted too much to material prosperity. The Indian way is not to reject the body, but to find a harmony between body and soul. To deal with the inevitable march of the machine and the dangers of totalitarianism of one sort or another, it provides intimations of other layers of being that lead to compassion and self-control. It opens up new vistas that shift the focus from being to becoming.

The Puranas have a charming story about how the gods came to become invincible, even though they started out as the weaker party. Shukra, the priest to the asuras, discovered, through science, the secret of reviving persons who had been killed in battle, and with this knowledge the asuras were able to subdue the gods. Brihaspati, who is the priest to the gods, recruited his son, Kacha, for obtaining this knowledge. Kacha presented himself to Shukra asking to be taken in as student. Even though he sensed danger in this, Shukra was helpless because one cannot turn away anyone who is seeking instruction.

Before long, Shukra's daughter Devayani fell in love with Kacha. The asuras were alarmed and they killed him on two occasions, but on his daughter's pleadings Shukra revived him. The third time the asuras not only killed him, but ground his body into powder and mixed it with the wine that they offered to Shukra. When Devayani found that Kacha was missing, she pleaded with her father for help and with his powers he found what had really happened. But this time he could not just revive Kacha within his belly because that would cause his own death. He had to first teach him what the secret of restoring life was so that when revived, he would bring back the dead Shukra to life. This done, Kacha returned with the secret knowledge to the gods, who again became ascendant.

The coming together of spiritual India and mechanical modernity is like the coming together of Kacha and Shukra that can only be good for all mankind. With wisdom, it should be possible for people, irrespective of their cultural and social background, to live together with compassion and harmony in pursuit of a way of life that values freedom and personal creativity.

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**ON THE BANKS OF
HOLY MANSAROVAR**



RAKSHAS TAAL

YAMDWAR**GETTING READY FOR PARIKRMA**



BEGINNING OF HOLY PARIKRAMA



**DIRAPHUK: HOLY
KAILASH NORTH FACE**



SWAMIJI PRAYING AT DIRAPHUK IN THE EARLY MORNING HOURS



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